



CITY: PG 3

Delhi govt doubles disaster staff pay



NATION: PG 5

PM speaks of 'forgiving' students; govt owes them justice, apology: Rahul



FILM: PG 12

'I'm here to find my own audience'

'NASHA MUKT YUVA FOR VIKSIT BHARAT SANKALP ABHIYAN'

PM launches 100-week anti-drug drive, calls on youth to lead change

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday launched the 'Nasha Mukta Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan', a nationwide campaign aimed at preventing substance abuse among young people, saying that a developed India can only be built if its youth remain mentally and physically healthy. Calling on young people to take a pledge against drugs, Modi said addiction may provide a temporary "high" but ultimately damages careers, families and lives. The initiative also marks the start of a 100-week public participation campaign, with awareness activities to be held every Sunday across the country to promote a drug-free society.

Launching the campaign virtually in the presence of a large gathering of young people, many of whom described themselves as representatives of Gen-Z, the prime minister said the movement was not meant only for the youth but also for their families, society and the nation. The event came days after large student protests in Delhi and several other parts of the country over demands for reforms in the public examination system.

Modi said India has set its



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the virtual launch of 'Nasha Mukta Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan'

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Campaign aims to prevent substance abuse among India's youth
- » Modi says a developed India needs mentally and physically fit youth
- » Youth urged to pledge against all forms of substance abuse
- » "Drugs give temporary high but make careers and lives low," Modi says
- » PM says addiction harms individuals and devastates entire families

sights on becoming a developed nation, making it necessary for young people to remain free from all forms of substance abuse so they can stay physically fit, mentally strong and confident.

"When the country has set the goal of building a developed India, it is essential that the youth stay away from harmful addictions to remain physically and mentally healthy and full of self-confidence. This is the objective of this campaign," he said.

Urging people across the

country to join the initiative, Modi said everyone should work to ensure that young people understand the dangers of drug addiction and remain alert to its risks. He said the campaign would gain strength through collective participation and would continue for the next 100 weeks.

"From today, the Nasha Mukta Yuva Abhiyan is being launched across the country. When this becomes a collective campaign, even those who are unable to do something on their own will receive new

energy," he said.

"The resolve taken today will move forward in the same manner for the next 100 weeks. Every Sunday, activities related to art, culture, sports, meditation, spirituality and service will be organised. The message of de-addiction will reach new people. The coming 100 Sundays will mark 100 strong steps towards a drug-free India," he added.

The nationwide Jan Bhagidari campaign will include sports competitions, walkathons, meditation sessions,

cultural programmes, awareness drives, nukkad natak, discussion forums, art competitions and community engagement programmes to encourage public participation in the anti-drug movement.

Modi said addiction affects not only the individual but also the entire family. He said it robs mothers of their happiness, shatters fathers' dreams, weakens the hopes of sisters and takes away the respect of younger brothers. Families, he said, live with the pain of watching their children gradually lose themselves.

Appealing to parents and guardians, the prime minister asked families not to hide addiction because of social stigma. Instead, he urged them to speak openly with their children and seek professional medical and expert help to support recovery.

He also challenged the social taboo surrounding people recovering from addiction, saying they should be viewed as fighters rather than judged for their past.

"Society should respect them, embrace them and give them a second chance," Modi said, adding that India's traditions teach that people can overcome substance abuse with the support

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Glasgow story: India sign off in fourth with 39-medal haul



From weightlifting to boxing, India rose together

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GLASGOW: India's campaign at the Commonwealth Games 2026 was never going to be judged solely by the number of medals it won. With Glasgow hosting a slimmed-down edition that excluded traditional Indian strongholds such as wrestling, shooting, badminton, table tennis, hockey and cricket, expectations were tempered from the outset. Yet, over 10 days of competition, the

Indian contingent produced a campaign defined by resilience, historic breakthroughs and record-breaking performances to finish fourth on the medals table with 39 medals comprising 13 gold, 17 silver and nine bronze.

It was a Games where established stars reaffirmed their class, emerging athletes announced themselves on the international stage and entire disciplines reached new milestones.

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COMMONWEALTH GAMES 2026 INDIA MEDAL TALLY					
GLASGOW 2026					
	GOLD	SILVER	BRONZE		TOTAL
INDIA	13	17	9		39
SPORT	GOLD	SILVER	BRONZE		TOTAL
WRESTLING	7	3	0		10
WRESTLING	0	5	5		10
WRESTLING	3	2	1		6
WRESTLING	1	7	1		9
WRESTLING	2	1	1		4
WRESTLING	0	0	1		1
TOTAL	13	17	9		39

NTA floats Rs 7.5-crore tender for 24x7 security of exam papers after NEET-UG paper leak

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has floated a tender worth about Rs 7.5 crore to appoint a professional agency for round-the-clock security services at its headquarters, regional offices and other sensitive locations, as part of efforts to strengthen the security of its examination system after the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak controversy.

According to the tender issued on July 25, the selected agency will provide security at the NTA headquarters on Minto Road in Delhi, its Okhla regional office and other notified locations. The agency will be responsible for protecting personnel, visitors, confidential examination material, server rooms, strong rooms, warehouses, record rooms and other sensitive facilities.

The contract will initially be for two years, with the option of two one-year extensions based on performance. Bids can be submitted until 3 pm on August 17, while technical bids will be opened later the same day.

The NTA also announced through its official social media accounts that it has invited separate bids through the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) for housekeeping, security and examination-grade printing services. The security and housekeeping tenders close on August 17, while the printing

Continued on P4

Pakistan: 14 dead in suicide attack during peace rally

PESHAWAR: At least 14 people, including five police personnel, were killed and more than 15 others injured in a suspected suicide attack outside a police station during a peace rally in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province on Sunday, officials said.

The blast took place while the Swat Peace Rally was underway opposite the Kabal Police Station in Kabal town of Swat district. The rally had been organised by the Swat Aman Jirga, a local tribal council, with participants carrying placards and raising slogans demanding peace. Protesters alleged that police inaction had contributed to a worsening security situation in recent months.

According to District Police Officer (DPO) Swat, the suspected suicide bomber tried to enter the Kabal Police Station and Police Lines



Police officers examine the site following a suicide bombing, in Kabal, a town in the Swat Valley in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, Sunday

compound but was stopped by security personnel at the main gate. The attacker then detonated the explosives, damaging the entrance but failing to breach the heavily guarded compound.

Regional Police Officer Syed Fida Hassan Shah said the police response prevented a far greater loss of life. "Casualties

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US Prez Trump says US to pause Iran strikes as ceasefire efforts continue

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said he would suspend new US strikes on Iran, claiming mediators had outlined a framework to end the five month conflict, reopen the Strait of Hormuz and curb Iran's nuclear threat. "I have

agreed... to cancel the attack," Trump wrote, adding any move depends on a deal. Iran said it remains alert. A mediator said no agreement has been reached. Separately, Israeli strikes in Gaza killed at least eight Palestinians, including two children.

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NDRF, FIRE AND RESCUE TEAMS DEPLOYED

Eight dead in Kerala rains as IMD warns of more downpours across several states

MPOST BUREAU

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Heavy rain continued to affect large parts of Kerala even as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) warned of more intense rainfall across several regions of the country. At least eight people have died, eight others remain missing and 13 have been injured after rain triggered landslides, flooding and widespread damage in Kerala on Saturday. While rainfall has eased in many parts of the state, authorities have urged people to remain alert as the IMD has forecast more heavy rain and issued weather warnings for several states, includ-



ing an orange alert for parts of the Northeast, Bihar and eastern India.

The IMD has issued an orange warning for heavy to very heavy rainfall over Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Sub Himalayan West Bengal

and Sikkim on Monday. Heavy rainfall is also expected over Jammu and Kashmir, Delhi, Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Jharkhand, Madhya Maharashtra and the Northeastern

CLOSER LOOK

- » IMD issues orange warning for Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Sub Himalayan West Bengal and Sikkim
- » Heavy rain forecast for Delhi, Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and several other states
- » Kerala under orange alert in 12 districts; more heavy rain expected on August 3 and 6

states. Similar conditions are likely over Odisha, Chhattisgarh,

Continued on P4



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Delhi’s fire shield set to grow

MHA clears proposal for over 10,700 new Delhi Fire Service posts

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major step towards strengthening Delhi’s emergency response system, the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has technically cleared a proposal to significantly expand the Delhi Fire Service (DFS) workforce by approving the creation of 10,743 new posts. The proposal, now awaiting procedural approval from the Delhi government, would increase the department’s sanctioned strength from 3,175 to 13,918 personnel, marking its first major manpower expansion since 2010.

The proposal was examined by the Directorate General of Fire Service, Civil Defence and Home Guards on the basis of Standing Fire Advisory Council (SFAC) guidelines, a consultant’s assessment and the capital’s growing urban and fire safety challenges.

Man absconding for 15 yrs arrested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested a man who had been absconding for 15 years in connection with a robbery-cum-murder of a commission agent in east Delhi, an officer said on Sunday. The accused, Naushad (37), who carried a bounty of Rs 10,000, was apprehended near Shastri Park Flyover on Friday.

The case pertains to the murder of Atul Jain, a commission agent at Gandhi Nagar Market, who was shot dead while returning home with cash collections on March 6, 2011.

According to the police, Jain was carrying around Rs 8.5 lakh in a bag when he was intercepted by a group of armed men on Mangal Bazar Road in Laxmi Nagar.

“The assailants allegedly attempted to rob him at gun-point. When Jain resisted, two of the accused, including Nau-shad and Bhura alias Mustkeen, opened fire, killing him before fleeing with the cash bag,” a senior police officer said.

Jain was taken to Dr Hedge-war Hospital, where he was declared brought dead.

A case was registered at the Shakarpur police station under charges of murder, robbery, criminal conspiracy and common intention.

Police said four accused, Arshad, Bhura alias Mustkeen, Nadeem alias Nadda and Zaki Anwar, were arrested, charge-sheeted and later convicted by a court. However, Naushad had evaded arrest and remained absconding. The Crime Branch was recently tasked with tracing the remaining accused, following which they began tracking Naushad’s movements.



Chief Fire Officer A.K. Malik said the expansion was planned after evaluating Delhi’s changing risk profile.

“The proposal has been prepared after assessing emerging fire hazards, urban risks and metropolitan operational demands. The additional manpower is essential to strengthen emergency response and build a modern metropolitan fire service,” he said.

Apart from firefighters, the

proposal includes specialised personnel for hazardous material (Hazmat) response, chemical, biological, radiological and nuclear (CBRN) emergencies, aerial ladder operations, search and rescue units, training institutions, technical wings, headquarters and multi-tasking staff. The MHA observed that while national benchmarks for several specialised posts do not exist, they are operationally justified for a metropolitan fire service.

HIGHLIGHTS

» The proposal, now awaiting procedural approval from the Delhi government, would increase the department’s sanctioned strength from 3,175 to 13,918 personnel, marking its first major manpower expansion since 2010

» According to DFS estimates, around 9,123 personnel are required to run the existing 71 operational fire stations under the current 24-hour shift system, but the department has only about 2,500 personnel, leaving a shortage of more than 6,600 staff

The move comes amid a severe staffing crunch in the department. According to DFS estimates, around 9,123 personnel are required to run the existing 71 operational fire stations under the current 24-hour shift system, but the department has only about 2,500 personnel, leaving a shortage of more than 6,600 staff.

Officials said the manpower requirement would increase substantially if the SFAC’s

recommended eight-hour shift system is implemented to reduce fatigue and improve efficiency. They added that Delhi currently has 71 operational fire stations against 120 sanctioned stations, with 49 stations yet to be built. The proposed manpower expansion has been planned keeping these future stations in view and is expected to improve response time and operational capacity across the city.

Delhi joins nationwide anti-drug drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh on Sunday called upon young people to lead the fight against substance abuse, saying a drug-free youth population is essential to achieving the vision of a developed India. He was addressing a programme under the ‘Nasha Mukti Yuva – Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan’ at Dr Bhim Rao Ambedkar College in Yamuna Vihar.

The event, organised by MY Bharat under the Ministry of

Youth Affairs and Sports, was attended by North East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari, college faculty, NSS and MY Bharat volunteers, students, NGO representatives and government officials. Participants also watched Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s virtual address and took a pledge for a drug-free India.

Addressing the gathering, Singh said, “Achieving the goal of a Developed India requires a generation of youth who are physically and mentally healthy and completely free from the menace of drugs.” He added

that the campaign marks the beginning of a 100-week nationwide movement, with activities every Sunday focusing on sports, culture, yoga, meditation, community service and public awareness.

The minister said the Delhi government, under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, is undertaking awareness initiatives to build a drug-free Delhi by connecting youth with education, sports, skill development and nation-building. Drawing a parallel with the annual Ramliila, he urged youngsters to choose the ideals of Lord

Ram over the evils symbolised by Ravana and stay away from drugs.

MP Manoj Tiwari said the campaign aims to instil confidence among youth to reject drugs and appealed to every participant to spread the anti-drug message to at least 100 others so that it grows into a nationwide people’s movement.

The programme concluded with participants signing a “Nasha Mukti Yuva – Viksit Bharat, Choose Life, Not Drugs” signature wall and taking a collective pledge against drug abuse.

Two Tillu gang shooters arrested after exchange of fire with police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police arrested two alleged shooters from the Tillu Tajpuriya gang following an exchange of fire in Rohini, cracking the recent murder of a rival gang member, an officer said on Sunday.

The accused, Vicky alias Rahul Ranga (27) and Vishal alias Sahil (26), allegedly opened fire on a police team that intercepted them on Saturday night near UER-II Road based on specific intelligence, police said.

According to police, a trap was laid after surveillance and specific intelligence on the suspects’ movement. As they reached the spot on a motorcycle, they allegedly attempted to flee and fired indiscriminately at the police team upon seeing them. Police retaliated in self-defence before apprehending them. The two sustained bullet

injuries in their legs in retaliatory firing by police and were overpowered. Officials said no police personnel were injured.

Police recovered two illegal pistols, six live cartridges, six empty cartridge cases and a motorcycle allegedly used in the July 30 murder of Harish Mathur, a member of the rival Gogi-Dinesh Karala gang.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rohini) Shashank Jaiswal said the motorcycle recovered from the accused was allegedly used in the killing of Mathur.

Police said the accused were allegedly in contact with a US-based associate of the Tillu Tajpuriya gang through encrypted communication applications and were receiving instructions from abroad.

“The handler arranged arms and money to be delivered to the accused by leaving them at an abandoned location on

the Kharkhoda-Rohtak Road, from where they collected the items,” the officer said.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly revealed that Mathur was targeted because of his association with the rival gang and that they had conducted reconnaissance of five to six other members of the group with plans to carry out further attacks.

“Their timely arrest has foiled a larger conspiracy and prevented further inter-gang violence,” Jaiswal said.

The DCP said Vicky has four criminal cases, including murder, attempt to murder and Arms Act offences, while Vishal is involved in three cases, including two under the Arms Act.

Police said both accused were shifted to the hospital and further investigation is underway to identify other members of the gang.

Mother, daughter die; Son survives Delhi snake bite

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 41-year-old woman and her 13-year-old daughter were bitten by a venomous snake they found in their bedroom. Her 18-year-old son was also bitten but survived the ordeal. According to the police, the incident happened in Delhi’s Bakhtawarpur area’s Triveni Colony on Wednesday when all 6 members of the family had slept in the same room.

It was around 4 am when Shafika Pravin alias Sakina first woke up after being bitten by the snake. She immediately informed the rest of the members of the family about the bite and told them that she had a snake bite on her hand.

While switching on the lights, the family saw a black snake slithering behind the clothes in the room. The 13-year-old girl and 18-year-old boy also revealed that they had suffered snake bites.

Later, a complaint came to us from Satyawadi Raja Harish Chandra (SRHC) hospital, Narela, about 3 snake bite case.

Sakina died during treatment while her daughter Aafiya’s condition worsened and she was shifted to Dr Baba Saheb Ambedkar (BSA) hospital, Rohini, but she too passed away within three hours of Sakina’s death. However, the 18-year-old boy survived after first aid.

A total of 6 people, including the wife and husband, their 2 sons, a daughter, and a relative, were sleeping when the incident occurred. The family has ruled out any possibility of foul play,

The incident took place in Triveni Colony in Delhi’s Bakhtawarpur area on Wednesday, when all 6 members of the family were sleeping in the same room

and police have begun inquest proceedings under section 194 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

The case was being treated as an accident, and police are awaiting the completion of all formalities.

“I find this incident unusual, and we need to investigate it thoroughly before coming to any conclusion,” said Faiyaz Khudsar, in-charge scientist of the Biodiversity Parks Program, Delhi.

“Only three poisonous snakes are there in Delhi – the cobra, viper and krait, and according to the police, there was a krait that was black in colour with some white rings, and it was around 1.5 metres in length. It has a potent venom, but it is a rare snake and is quite slow,” he added.

Triveni Colony is the northernmost part of Delhi, wherein residential colonies are also in proximity to open lands.

During the monsoon, snakes tend to come out of their burrows due to waterlogging, and this leads to encounters with humans as they come searching for food and shelter.

NATURE PUTS ON A SHOW



A peacock displays its plumage during the monsoon season, at National Zoological Park, in New Delhi, on Sunday

PTI

Heat, humidity trouble Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: It was hot and humid in Delhi on Sunday as the city recorded a maximum temperature of 35.7 degrees Celsius, 1.3 notches above normal, the weather office said.

Humidity levels oscillated between 70-85 per cent during the day. The national capital witnessed 1 mm rainfall during the day, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The minimum temperature settled at 26.2 degrees Celsius, 0.9 notch below normal. The city also witnessed trace rainfall between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, while 1 mm of rainfall was recorded during the 24-hour period ending at 8.30 am at Safdarjung.

The IMD has forecast a cloudy sky with light for Monday. The maximum and minimum temperatures are likely to settle around 32 degrees Celsius and 24 degrees Celsius, respectively.

Among other weather stations, Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 34.9 degrees Celsius and a min-



REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

imum of 25 degrees Celsius, Lodhi Road recorded 34.6 degrees Celsius and 25.8 degrees Celsius, Ridge recorded 33.4 degrees Celsius and 22.3 degrees Celsius, while Ayanagar recorded 35 degrees Celsius and 26.4 degrees Celsius, respectively.

The air quality was recorded in the ‘satisfactory’ category at 4

pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 77, according to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

According to the CPCB, an AQI between 0 and 50 is considered ‘good’, 51 and 100 “satisfactory”, 101 and 200 “moderate”, 201 and 300 “poor”, 301 and 400 “very poor”, and 401 and 500 “severe”.

Noida: Four-year-old drowns in uncovered water tank; FIR filed

DIIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: A four-year-old boy died after allegedly falling into an uncovered water tank near a slum settlement in Sector 122 on Friday, leading his family to accuse the Noida Authority of negligence and prompting police to register an FIR.

The victim, identified as Firoz Alam, alias Golu, had reportedly gone to wash his hands at a water tank located beside a tubewell near his home. Police said the child is believed to have lost his balance and fallen into the nearly four-foot-deep tank.

His mother began searching for him after calling him for breakfast and finding him missing. Around 10 am, the family discovered the boy floating in the tank. His father, Shirajuddin Alam, immediately pulled him out and tried to revive him before local residents alerted the police through Dial 112.

A police team from the Parthala outpost and an ambulance reached the spot and rushed the child to the district hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

KEY POINTS

» The victim, identified as Firoz Alam, alias Golu, had reportedly gone to wash his hands at a water tank located beside a tubewell near his home

» Police said the child is believed to have lost his balance and fallen into the nearly four-foot-deep tank

» A police team from the Parthala outpost and an ambulance reached the spot and rushed the child to the district hospital, where doctors declared him dead

Shirajuddin, a daily-wage worker employed in the horticulture department of the Noida Authority, later filed a complaint at Sector 113 police station against Authority officials and employees. He alleged

that the site lacked basic safety measures, claiming the main gate had been left open while the water tank remained uncovered and without any protective barricading.

He said the fatal accident could have been prevented if the premises had been secured, the tank covered, or a security guard deployed.

Police said they are verifying the family’s allegations and identifying the department responsible for maintaining the site and ensuring compliance with safety norms.

Based on the complaint, an FIR has been registered against the Noida Authority under Section 105 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (culpable homicide not amounting to murder).

The incident comes days after another child died in similar circumstances. On July 25, six-year-old Ayaan Surya drowned in a rainwater-filled pit dug for a tubewell at Kalandham Society in Knowledge Park, where the excavation was allegedly left unsecured by contractors engaged by the Greater Noida Authority.

City Briefs

SIX BANGLADESHI NATIONALS SENT TO DETENTION CENTRE

NEW DELHI: Six Bangladeshi nationals have been shifted to a detention centre after being detained by Delhi Police for violating the conditions of their double-entry visas by staying beyond the permissible duration, officials said on Sunday. The six were detained during the inspection of hotels and guest houses as part of a verification drive in central Delhi. They were found staying at a hotel on Arakashan Road in Nabi Karim. Verification of their visas and immigration records revealed that although their visas were valid, each visit permitted a maximum stay of 15 days, which they had exceeded, police said. The six were produced before the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO), which issued restriction orders and shifted them to a detention centre for deportation proceedings.

MAN HELD FOR PLANTING PISTOLS TO FALSELY IMPLICATE RELATIVE

NEW DELHI: A man has been arrested for allegedly planting illegal firearms at his relative’s rented house and tipping off police under a fake identity in an attempt to implicate him in an Arms Act case, an officer said on Sunday. The accused, Mohammad Waseem (28), was arrested on Saturday after police during investigation by the police during the investigation of an Arms Act case registered earlier this month. According to the police, Waseem allegedly harboured a grudge against his relative, Mohammad Ashraf, for marrying his sister-in-law against the family’s wishes.

Ggm Forest Department employees hold protest

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Gurugram Forest Department employees laid siege to the Civil Lines residence of Haryana Cabinet Minister Rao Narbir Singh on Sunday, demanding the regularisation of contractual workers and the implementation of “equal pay for equal work.” Additionally, the employee representatives demanded the timely disbursement of salaries and the provision of social security benefits to contractual and temporary staff.

Their demands also

Demand equal pay for equal work

included the removal of corrupt employees from the department and a minimum wage of Rs 26,000. Identity cards should be issued to all employees. A sum of Rs 10 lakh should be paid upon retirement. All employees who have won their court cases should be reinstated and all former employees should be recalled with immediate effect. As a precautionary measure, the police erected heavy barricades on the roads leading to Singh’s residence. Employees, however, staged a sit-in protest close to his residence and raised slogans. Additional police forces have been summoned to the scene.

Govt notifies prisoner death relief scheme for kin

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Kin of prison inmates who die there under unnatural circumstances will be eligible for compensation up to Rs 7.5 lakh under a scheme notified by the Delhi government. The compensation will be paid to the next of kin or the legal heirs of prisoners who suffer unnatural death while in custody in city jails. Under the scheme, a sum between Rs 5 lakh and Rs 7.5 lakh will be provided depending on the circumstances of each case, the Chief Minister's Office said in a statement.

According to the notification, Rs 7.5 lakh will be paid to the family of a prisoner in cases where the death occurred

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The compensation will be paid to the next of kin or the legal heirs of prisoners who suffer unnatural death while in custody in city jails
- » Under the scheme, a sum between Rs 5 lakh and Rs 7.5 lakh will be provided depending on the circumstances...
- » According to the notification, Rs 7.5 lakh will

- be paid to the family of a prisoner in cases where the death occurred due to clashes between inmates or alleged torture or assault by prison authorities
- » A compensation of Rs 5 lakh has been prescribed in cases involving negligence by prison authorities or staff, negligence by medical or paramedical personnel, or suicide by a prisoner

sonnel, or suicide by a prisoner. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the scheme, notified in accordance with the guidelines of the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), will ensure timely relief to affected families in specified cases and will strengthen administrative accountability. According to the notification issued by the Home Department of the Delhi government, the Scheme for Payment of Compensation on Account of Death of Prisoners in Delhi Prison, 2025, will apply only to cases involving the unnatural death of a prisoner in any Delhi prison on or after the date of notification. The notification stipulates that no compensation will be payable in cases of natural

death or death caused by illness. Deaths occurring while escaping from prison or from lawful custody, as well as deaths caused by disasters or calamities, will not be covered under the scheme. The jail superintendent will be required to submit the magisterial inquiry report, post-mortem report, final cause of death, the prisoner's medical history, and details of the treatment provided before death to the Director General (Prisons), Delhi, in every case. These cases will be reviewed by a committee headed by the Director General (Prisons), with the Assistant Inspector General (Prisons), the Resident Medical Officer, the Deputy Controller (Accounts), and the Law Officer as its members.

Delhi govt doubles disaster staff pay

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In order to provide relief for personnel working under the Delhi State Disaster Management Authority (DSDMA), the Delhi government on Sunday approved a remuneration hike of up to 100 per cent for Project Officers (POs), District Project Officers (DPOs) and Project Coordinators (PCs), marking the first revision in their pay since 2009. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the decision would correct a long-pending anomaly and strengthen the Capital's disaster preparedness.

"We have delivered justice to disaster management personnel by revising remuneration that remained unchanged for 16 years," Gupta said, adding that the revised structure reflects their responsibilities, experience and technical expertise rather than being an ex gratia benefit. The Chief Minister said the posts were created in 2009 with support from the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), but their monthly remuneration remained fixed at Rs 25,000 for POs and DPOs and Rs 20,000 for PCs despite rising inflation and expanding responsibilities. Unlike regular government employees, they were neither linked to any pay structure nor entitled to periodic revisions or Dearness Allowance (DA). Highlighting their role, Gupta said the personnel prepare disaster management plans, conduct risk assessments, coordinate emergency operations with agencies such as the NDRF, SDRF, Fire



TAKEAWAYS

- » Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the decision would correct a long-pending anomaly and strengthen the Capital's disaster preparedness
- » We have delivered justice to disaster management personnel by revising remuneration that remained unchanged for 16 years, says CM
- » The Chief Minister said the posts were created in 2009 with support

from the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), but their monthly remuneration remained fixed at Rs 25,000 for POs and DPOs and Rs 20,000 for PCs despite rising inflation and expanding responsibilities. Unlike regular government employees, they were neither linked to any pay structure nor entitled to periodic revisions or Dearness Allowance (DA).

Services, Police and Health Department, besides organising mock drills and capacity-building programmes. "The government's objective is not merely to increase remuneration, but to build a disaster management system that is stronger, more modern and better prepared for future

challenges," she said, adding that the move would also strengthen the safety of Delhi's nearly 3.2 crore residents. The government also indicated it would consider annual performance-based increments, medical coverage and training opportunities for the cadre in future.

NDMC holds plantation drive

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Sunday conducted its 35th consecutive plantation drive under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign at RWA Block 58-70, Sector-2, Kali Bari Marg. The drive was led by NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal and saw participation from local residents, Resident Welfare Association (RWA) representatives and civic officials. Saplings were planted in honour of mothers as part of the campaign aimed at promoting environmental conservation and public participation. Chahal said the completion of 35 consecutive weeks reflected growing public awareness and participation in environmental initiatives. He said the campaign had evolved beyond plantation into a community-led movement involving RWAs, educational institutions, embassies and social organisations. He also stressed that planting saplings must be followed by their regular care, protection and maintenance to ensure their survival.

During the programme, residents raised civic concerns related to tree pruning, sewerage and other local issues. Chahal directed the concerned departments to inspect the matters and ensure their time-bound resolution. Officials from NDMC's civil, electrical, horticulture, water supply and sewerage departments also participated in the plantation drive. Chahal urged residents to take responsibility for nurturing the saplings and make environmental conservation a sustained community effort.



CM REKHA GUPTA INSPECTS LBS HOSPITAL



CM Rekha Gupta during a visit to the Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital in Mayur Vihar Phase-2, for the inspection of cleanliness, availability of medicines, and medical services, on Sunday

Mayor launches 'Aerobin' DDA cuts grievance pendency by over 85% in six months

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi on Sunday inaugurated an 'Aerobin' at Shree Apartment Housing Society in Rohini Sector 15, as part of efforts to promote segregation and processing of wet waste at the source. The Mayor said the Aerobin uses bio-culture technology to convert up to 10 kg of wet waste into compost in a single cycle. The process takes around 40 days and, according to the civic body, does not generate foul odour. Wahi urged housing societies across the city to adopt such decentralised waste-processing systems, saying that treating waste at the source could reduce the quantity of garbage reaching landfill sites. He said the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) had also inducted several modern machines into its sanitation fleet in recent months to improve cleanliness standards across the city. Calling for greater public participation, Wahi appealed to Delhi residents to cooperate with the MCD in maintaining cleanliness in their neighbourhoods. He said community-level initiatives were



important to achieving the goal of a cleaner and greener capital. **Mayor inaugurates health check-up camp** Wahi also inaugurated a health check-up camp at the housing society. Emphasising the importance of preventive

healthcare, he urged residents to pay greater attention to their health amid increasingly fast-paced lifestyles. He said community initiatives combining environmental cleanliness with health awareness could contribute to improving residents' overall quality of life.

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has reduced its grievance pendency by over 85 per cent in the six-month period beginning January this year, bringing the number of pending grievances down from 22,946 at the start of the year to 3,167 by the end of June. The DDA resolved 19,779 grievances received through multiple platforms, including CPGRAMS, L-G Listening Post, CM Jan Sunwai/PGMS, DRMS, Mobile 311 and Samasya Nidan Sewa. The improvement follows Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu's emphasis on citizen-centric governance and directions to proactively address citizens' complaints and grievances. The L-G had instructed departments to be more responsive and efficient to achieve the goal of Viksit Delhi. He also directed the DDA to adopt transparent, responsive and accountable governance and ensure grievances are addressed promptly while substantially

reducing the backlog of pending cases. As part of the public centric approach, the DDA conducts bi-weekly Public Hearings every working Monday and Thursday, allowing walk-in visitors to present their queries and grievances directly. People can interact with Deputy Directors and Directors between 2:30 pm and 4:30 pm, and Commissioners and above between 2:30 pm and 3:30 pm, without prior appointment. Around 6,000 people visit the DDA every month during Public Hearing days. The Vice Chairman, DDA, has regularly sensitised officers across departments to accord highest priority to grievance disposal. Cases are also continuously reviewed through follow-up with concerned departments and field units. The DDA will continue strengthening grievance redressal through technology-enabled monitoring, regular performance reviews, bi-weekly Public Hearings, enhanced departmental accountability and sustained follow-up.



Believe, achieve, serve: L-G Sandhu to DU students

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar TS Sandhu urged students to believe in themselves, have confidence in India's institutions and opportunities, and combine excellence with integrity, discipline and a commitment to public service while addressing the Orientation Programme 2026 of Kirori Mal College, University of Delhi. Sharing a personal reflection, Sandhu said, "I am a product of Delhi University," recalling that he completed both his graduation and post-graduation in Delhi and had never studied abroad. He said whatever he had been able to contribute in service of the nation overseas was built on the foundation laid at Delhi University. His message to students was to believe in themselves, have confidence in India's institutions, opportunities and their own capabilities, adding that "the future is yours to shape".

KEY POINTS

- » He said whatever he had been able to contribute in service of the nation overseas was built on the foundation laid at Delhi University
- » His message to students was to believe in themselves, have confidence in India's institutions, opportunities and their own capabilities, adding that 'the future is yours to shape'

shape. Sandhu also congratulated students and faculty mentors who were felicitated for publishing research papers under the Four-Year Undergraduate Programme, calling it a reflection of a healthy academic culture where inquiry begins early. During the programme, the LG inaugurated the Kirori Mal College Incubation Centre and the Science Block Lift. Referring to innovation and entrepreneurship, he said universities must continue to nurture research, innovation and entrepreneurship as India moves towards a Viksit Bharat by 2047. Concluding his address, Sandhu urged students to cultivate intellectual curiosity, scientific temperament and independent thinking, while ensuring excellence remains accompanied by integrity, discipline and public service, whatever path they choose.

AIR POLLUTION SPEEDING UP DETERIORATION IIT study warns of Humayun's Tomb decay

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A black crust formed on the sandstone of Humayun's Tomb in Delhi by years of exposure to air pollution is accelerating the deterioration of the UNESCO World Heritage Site, a joint study of IIT Roorkee and IIT Kanpur has found. Published in the International Journal of Architectural Heritage, the study examined black crust samples collected from different parts of Humayun's Tomb using laboratory techniques to analyse their chemical composition, mineral content and microscopic structure. The researchers found that the black crust is mainly made up of gypsum — a mineral formed when sulphur dioxide

CLOSER LOOK

- » The researchers found that the black crust is mainly made up of gypsum — a mineral formed when sulphur dioxide in polluted air reacts with calcium-rich dust and moisture, the study showed
- » The gypsum layer traps soot, dust and tiny metal particles from vehicle emissions, construction activities, road dust, biomass burning and industrial pollution, gradually forming a dark coating on the sandstone

- » The study found that the thickest black crust developed in rain-sheltered parts of the monument, where pollutants accumulate over long periods, while more exposed surfaces had comparatively thinner deposits because rain naturally washes away some of the pollutants
- » It also suggested reducing pollution at the source through cleaner transport and lower-emission fuels to slow the formation of the damaging deposits

in polluted air reacts with calcium-rich dust and moisture, the study showed. The gypsum layer traps soot, dust and tiny metal particles from vehicle emissions, construction activities, road dust, biomass burning and industrial pollution, gradually forming a dark coating on the sandstone, it mentioned. The study found that the thickest black crust developed in rain-sheltered parts of the monument, where pollutants accumulate over long periods, while more exposed surfaces had comparatively thinner deposits because rain naturally washes away some of the pollutants. According to the researchers, the black crust is more than a surface stain. The chemical reactions that form the crust

gradually weaken the sandstone, making it more vulnerable to weathering and long-term deterioration. They said the findings provide scientific evidence linking air pollution to the deterioration of Humayun's Tomb and could help authorities plan conservation measures for the monument. The study recommended periodic removal of the black crust using scientifically tested conservation methods, continuous monitoring of pollution around the monument and evaluation of protective coatings before their use. It also suggested reducing pollution at the source through cleaner transport and lower-emission fuels to slow the formation of the damaging deposits.

The researchers said the findings could help conservation agencies prioritise preventive measures and develop site-specific strategies to protect Humayun's Tomb from further pollution-related deterioration. Humayun's Tomb, built in the 16th century by Empress Bega Begum in memory of Mughal emperor Humayun, is regarded as India's first grand garden tomb. The red sandstone and white marble monument introduced several architectural features that later influenced Mughal monuments, including the Taj Mahal. The UNESCO World Heritage Site is one of Delhi's best-known historical monuments and attracts visitors from across the world.

ASSURES LEGAL SUPPORT TO TEENAGER BOOKED OVER ANTI-PM REMARKS

CJP core panel to meet on Aug 5

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) will hold a meeting of its core committee in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar on August 5 to decide its next course of action following the nationwide protests over the NEET-UG paper leak that culminated in the resignation of former Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The meeting will take place at the hometown of CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, who resides there with his parents.

The party had recently warned that it would launch a larger agitation if students and youth who participated in the protests were allegedly subjected to harassment by the Centre or state governments.

Meanwhile, an RTI activist has sought an inquiry into the assets of Dipke's father, Bhagwanrao Dipke, a former junior engineer with the Maharashtra



As a few protests continued at Jantar Mantar on Monday, remnants of the month-long CJP agitation lay scattered near the site, two days after the protest ended

Industrial Development Corporation (MIDC).

He questioned how the family could allegedly afford overseas education for their children and claimed a complaint had been submitted to the Maharashtra government seeking an investigation into possible disproportion-

ate assets.

Separately, CJP spokesperson Ratna Singh said she had spoken to the mother of a Noida-based teenager booked for allegedly making abusive remarks against Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the party's protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar.

Highlights

- » The meeting will take place at the hometown of CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, who resides there with his parents
- » Meanwhile, an RTI activist has sought an inquiry into the assets of Dipke's father, Bhagwanrao Dipke, a former junior engineer with the Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation

on the family.

Singh said the party would not initiate any legal action against the teenager and would instead provide legal assistance, counselling and other support if needed.

The case gained attention after a video of the teenager's remarks went viral.

A Zero FIR was initially registered in Noida before being transferred to Delhi's Parliament Street police station, where the alleged incident took place.

The teenager later apologised, saying she had been influenced by people at the protest and described the episode as her "first and last mistake."

The girl's mother had earlier thanked Prime Minister Modi for publicly appealing against punitive action and urged authorities to withdraw the FIR, claiming her daughter is a 15-year-old minor and that her age was recorded incorrectly in the complaint.

Ayodhya: 2nd SIT will analyse afresh evidence related to theft of offerings

OUR CORRESPONDENT



and evidence collected during the investigation.

It is also conducting a fresh scrutiny of State Bank of India officials, outsourced staff and other personnel connected with the collection and counting of donations to ascertain whether any of them had any involvement in the alleged offence.

The new SIT has issued notices to more than 200 people for questioning, sources said, adding that former trust general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra may also be questioned.

The FIR in the case was registered based on a preliminary report submitted by the first SIT headed by Lucknow Divisional Commissioner

Vijay Vishwas Pant. Police had arrested eight accused in connection with the alleged theft and recorded statements of trust office-bearers.

Sources further claimed that the scope of the probe has widened to include alleged financial irregularities in expenditure on religious ceremonies and festivals at the temple.

The latest developments come as the trust has stepped up surveillance over the handling of donations. Trust member Mahant Dinendra Das on Saturday said the investigation into the alleged irregularities involving gold, silver and other offerings had reached its final stage.

Since July 25, every stage of the donation handling process has been placed under continuous videographic surveillance, while additional CCTV cameras and an eight-member monitoring team have been deployed to enhance transparency.

Worship and darshan at the temple continue as usual, he had said.

Glasgow story: India sign off fourth with 39-medal haul

Continued from Page 1

From Mirabai Chanu Saikhom's third Commonwealth Games title to a boxing squad that scripted India's greatest-ever performance at the event, Glasgow offered enough memorable moments to ensure the campaign will be remembered long after the closing ceremony. The first signs of promise came from the weightlifting arena, where India's dependable lifters once again lived up to expectations. Mirabai Chanu Saikhom opened India's gold account by lifting her way to the women's 48kg title, becoming a three-time Commonwealth Games champion after her successes in Gold Coast and Birmingham. The Olympic silver medallist's latest triumph reinforced her place among India's greatest Commonwealth athletes and gave the contingent the ideal start.

The weightlifting team continued to swell India's medal tally through consistent podium finishes. Rishikanta Singh Chanambam claimed silver in the men's 60kg category, followed by Raja Muthupandi in the men's 65kg division. Gyaneshwari Yadav added silver in the women's 53kg event, while Valluri Ajaya Babu finished second in the men's 79kg category. Harjinder Kaur earned another silver in the women's 69kg competition, and Lovepreet Singh completed the silver collection in the men's +110kg class. Bindaryani Devi Sorokhaibam rounded off the weightlifting campaign with bronze in the women's 58kg event, giving India an impres-

sive nine medals from the sport. If weightlifting provided the early momentum, para sport supplied the defining breakthroughs.

The biggest milestone came through Sharmila, who became the first Indian to win a Commonwealth Games gold medal in para athletics after topping the podium in the women's F57 shot put. It was a landmark moment not only for Indian para athletics but for the country's sporting movement as a whole.

India's para athletics success continued through Dilip Mahadu Gavit, who stormed to gold in the men's 100m T47 event, adding another historic title to the country's tally. Soman Rana made it a third para athletics gold by winning the men's F57 shot put, while Mohammed Basil Mossing-ganakath secured silver in the men's 100m T47. Shubham Juyal added another silver in the men's F57 shot put, and Shilpa Kanchugarakoppalu Shyla joined Sharmila on the podium with finishes in the women's F57 event.

Along with Jhandu Kumar's bronze in men's heavyweight para powerlifting, India's para contingent delivered its finest Commonwealth Games campaign, highlighting the rapid rise of para sport in the country.

Athletics, too, emerged as one of India's brightest stories in Glasgow.

Distance runner Gulveer Singh enjoyed a breakthrough Games, winning silver in the men's 10,000m before returning to collect bronze in the 5,000m, making him one of India's multiple medallists at

the Games. Olympic champion Neeraj Chopra added another major international medal with silver in the men's javelin throw, while Murali Sreeshankar continued his consistency with silver in the men's long jump. High jumper Sarvesh Anil Kushare matched that achievement by clearing his way to another silver medal, and Praveen Chithravel completed India's silver haul in athletics with a runner-up finish in the men's triple jump.

The athletics bronze medals reflected the growing depth of Indian track and field. Tejaswin Shankar battled through two demanding days of competition to secure bronze in the decathlon, Yash Vir Singh finished third in the men's javelin throw, Selva Prabhu Thirumaran earned bronze in the triple jump, and Seema added another podium finish in the women's discus throw. Collectively, the athletics squad demonstrated that India is no longer dependent on a handful of stars but is steadily building strength across multiple disciplines.

Judo quietly produced one of India's most productive campaigns of the Games. Asmita Dey won gold in the women's 48kg category, while Harsh Singh captured the men's 60kg title to give India a pair of judo champions. Yamini Mourya added silver in the women's 57kg division, and Unnati Sharma completed the medal collection with bronze in the women's 63kg category, confirming India's growing competitiveness in the sport.

Then came the final act that transformed a good cam-

paign into a historic one.

On the penultimate day of competition, Indian boxing delivered a performance unlike any seen before at the Commonwealth Games. The contingent amassed 10 medals, including seven gold and three silver, making it India's most successful boxing campaign in Commonwealth Games history. The women's team led the charge. Sakshi Chaudhary won the women's 51kg title, Preeti Pawar followed with gold in the 54kg category, Jaimine Lamboria triumphed in the women's 57kg division, Priya captured the women's 60kg crown, and Arundhati Choudhary completed the gold rush in the women's 70kg class. Olympic medallist Lovlina Borgohain added silver in the women's 75kg event after another composed campaign.

The men matched that success. Sachin Siwach fought his way to gold in the men's 60kg category, Ankush Panghal topped the podium in the men's 80kg division, while Jadumani Singh Mandengbam earned silver in the men's 55kg class and Narender Berwal added another silver in the super-heavyweight (+90kg) category. Those performances lifted India into fourth place on the medals table and capped a remarkable late surge that saw the country collect a significant portion of its medals during the closing stages of the Games.

While India's final tally of 13 gold, 17 silver and nine bronze was lower than previous Commonwealth Games because of the reduced sports programme, the campaign carried greater significance

than the numbers alone suggest. Glasgow 2026 was about milestones.

It was the Games where Mirabai Chanu Saikhom became a three-time Commonwealth champion. It was where Sharmila became India's first Commonwealth para athletics gold medallist. It was where Dilip Mahadu Gavit and Soman Rana showcased India's growing dominance in para athletics. It was where Gulveer Singh emerged as one of India's most versatile track athletes, and where Neeraj Chopra, Murali Sreeshankar and Sarvesh Anil Kushare reaffirmed their consistency on the international stage. Above all, it was the Games where Indian boxing reached unprecedented heights. The combined brilliance of Sakshi Chaudhary, Preeti Pawar, Jaimine Lamboria, Priya, Arundhati Choudhary, Sachin Siwach, Ankush Panghal, Jadumani Singh Mandengbam, Narender Berwal and Lovlina Borgohain rewrote the national record books and ensured India departed Glasgow with its finest-ever boxing performance at the Commonwealth Games.

The medal table will record that India finished fourth with 39 medals. History, however, is likely to remember Glasgow 2026 for something more enduring: a campaign in which new heroes emerged, established champions strengthened their legacies and Indian sport proved that, even with fewer opportunities, it could continue to broaden its horizons and compete with the Commonwealth's very best.

From Page 1

PM launches

of society, along with yoga and meditation.

Referring to drug trafficking, the prime minister said hostile countries use the supply of narcotics as part of their terror plans because they know that India's youth represent the country's future. He said the government was taking strict action against drug networks across the country.

"Strict action is being taken against drug traffickers across the country. The arrests have gone up several times as compared to before, and drugs worth thousands of crores of rupees have been seized. This shows how strongly our government is acting against drugs," he said.

The 'Nasha Mukti Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan' seeks to inspire young people to stay away from substance abuse and become ambassadors of positive social change in their communities.

Addressing the launch, Union Minister for Youth Affairs and Sports Mansukh Mandaviya said the Nasha Mukti Bharat Abhiyaan, launched in 2020, was introduced in line with the prime minister's vision of building a drug-free India. He said the new youth-focused campaign would carry that effort forward by mobilis-

ing public participation over the next 100 weeks through sustained awareness and community engagement across the country.

NEET-UG paper leak

services tender closes on August 20.

Unlike the lowest-bid system commonly used in government procurement, the NTA has opted for the Quality and Cost Based Selection (QCBS) method. Under this process, technical proposals will account for 70 per cent of the final score and financial bids for the remaining 30 per cent. Agencies scoring below 70 marks in the technical evaluation will not qualify for financial assessment.

Eligible bidders must have at least five years of experience in the security sector, an average annual turnover of Rs 10 crore over the previous three financial years and experience providing security to central government institutions or other high-security establishments such as examination bodies, universities, airports, hospitals and metro networks.

The estimated contract value is around Rs 7.5 crore, excluding GST. Bidders must submit an earnest money deposit of Rs 15 lakh and the successful agency will be required to furnish performance security equal to 5 per

cent of the contract value.

The selected agency will regulate entry to NTA premises by verifying the identity of employees and visitors, restricting access to authorised personnel and maintaining visitor records. Security checks will include door-frame and hand-held metal detectors. The agency will also protect confidential examination material, digital infrastructure and secure storage facilities while deploying GPS-enabled guard patrol tracking, biometric attendance systems and digital incident reporting platforms.

The tender also requires the agency and its personnel to maintain strict confidentiality regarding examination processes, security arrangements and IT infrastructure, with these obligations continuing even after the contract ends.

The move comes after the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, which led to the cancellation of the May 3 examination and a re-test on June 21.

Pakistan

could have been much higher had the attacker entered the Kabal Police Compound," he said.

A Rescue 1122 Swat spokesperson said nine bodies were taken to Central Hospital Saidu Sharif, while Kabal Hospital confirmed five more deaths, raising

the toll to 14. Deputy Inspector General Malakand said those killed included five police personnel, among them an officer, three civilians and one child.

Rescue operations, directed by Rescue 1122 Director General Shah Fahad and supervised by District Emergency Officer Shoaib Mansoor, continued through the evening. By 9 pm local time, emergency teams had treated and shifted more than 15 injured people to hospitals.

The Kabal Police Compound houses the police station, Police Lines, a facilitation centre and several government offices.

Security forces sealed the area and began an investigation, collecting forensic evidence. No group immediately claimed responsibility for the attack.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Muhammad Suhail Afridi and Governor Faisal Karim Kundi condemned the blast. The chief minister also directed the Inspector General of Police to submit a report and expressed condolences to the families of those killed. AGENCIES

Eight dead

Karnataka, Kerala, Mahe, Konkan, Goa, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

Thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and gusty winds have also been forecast over Madhya Pradesh, Vidarbha,

Telangana, Coastal Andhra Pradesh and Lakshadweep for the next two days. For Delhi, the weather office has predicted light rain during the afternoon and evening on Monday.

In Kerala, Chief Minister V D Satheesan said eight people have lost their lives in the rain-related incidents, while eight remained missing. A total of 13 people were injured. The disaster has damaged homes and forced thousands to leave their villages. According to the Chief Minister's Office, 27 houses were completely destroyed and another 196 suffered partial damage. Around 5,792 people have been shifted to 209 relief camps across the state.

The Chief Minister said the government would provide assistance to families of those who died as well as people who lost their homes and livelihoods. He urged residents, especially those living in hilly areas, to remain cautious despite a decline in rainfall. Satheesan said he was in constant touch with Revenue Minister A P Anilkumar, other ministers and district authorities to monitor relief work. He also appealed to volunteers, political party workers and social organisations to join cleaning operations in flood-hit areas.

The IMD has issued an orange alert for 12 districts in Kerala and a yellow alert for Thiruvananthapuram and Kollam. An orange alert indicates very heavy rainfall of 11 cm to

20 cm, while a yellow alert signifies heavy rainfall between 6 cm and 11 cm. The department has forecast more heavy rain in Kerala on August 3 and August 6, along with winds of 40 to 50 kmph.

The IMD has also advised fishermen not to venture into the Kerala, Karnataka and Lakshadweep coast on August 2 and 3 because of strong winds that could reach 60 km/h and rough sea conditions. The Indian National Centre for Ocean Information Services has warned of high waves ranging from 2.7 metres to 3.5 metres along the northern Kerala coast and asked fishermen and coastal residents to remain alert.

Revenue Minister A P Anilkumar said the situation was improving and remained under control despite widespread waterlogging and damage. He said traffic had resumed on many roads, although restrictions were still in place on some stretches. He added that all necessary preparations had been made in districts likely to receive more rain.

According to the Kerala State Disaster Management Authority, some areas recorded up to 320 mm of rainfall on Saturday. The highest rainfall of 320 mm was reported at Ayanankunnu in Kannur district, while several places across the Malabar region received between 90 mm and 180 mm from 3 am until midnight.

Floodwater entered homes

in low-lying areas of Pathanamthitta, Idukki, Wayanad, Kottayam, Kozhikode and Kannur districts. On Sunday, waterlogging continued in places such as Ranni in Pathanamthitta and Kuttanad in Alappuzha, where people relied on small boats for transport. Water levels in several power generation dams in Idukki, Pathanamthitta and Thrissur districts also remained in the red alert zone.

Tourism Minister P C Vishnunad said an additional National Disaster Response Force team had been deployed in Pathanamthitta and Aranmula, while extra Fire and Rescue Services personnel had been moved from Thiruvananthapuram, Palakkad and Ernakulam. Fishermen and fishing boats have also been kept ready for rescue operations, particularly in Aranmula where floodwaters usually take longer to recede.

Meanwhile, BJP leader P C George said his house in Erattupetta in Kottayam district was flooded, causing property losses worth lakhs of rupees. Senior CPI(M) leader K N Balagopal, after visiting flood-hit areas in Ranni, said traders had suffered major losses and alleged that many shop owners had not received prior warning before dams were opened. Educational institutions in Pathanamthitta, Wayanad, Kannur and Kasaragod will remain closed on Monday due to the continuing weather threat.

GANDHI MADE THE REMARKS IN AN INSTAGRAM POST

PM speaks of ‘forgiving’ students; govt owes them justice, apology, says Rahul

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi speaks of “forgiving” students, but it is the government that owes the students truth, justice and an apology.

Gandhi made the remarks in an Instagram post as he shared a video of his interaction with the families of Gopika, Roshini and Vetri Anandan, who committed suicide following the NEET paper leak and cancellation, during his visit to Tamil Nadu on Saturday.

The leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said, “During my visit to Tamil Nadu, I met the families of Gopika, Roshini and Vetri Anandan, three young medical aspirants whose lives were lost following the NEET paper leak and the cancellation of the examination. Each family was left with the same painful question: why should honest,



LoP in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi meets family members and relatives of NEET victims during his visit to Chennai

PTI

hardworking students pay the price for a dishonest system?”

A leaked paper led to a cancelled examination, a forced NEET re-exam and unbearable pressure on young minds, Gandhi said. Behind every statistic is a child with a dream and a family now living with an irreplaceable loss, he said.

“I listened to their pain. Our fight is for an education system where hard work is respected,

examinations are fair and no student is pushed to the edge because institutions failed them,” the former Congress chief said.

“The Prime Minister speaks of ‘forgiving’ students. After listening to these parents, my conviction is even stronger: India’s students need no forgiveness. The government owes them truth, justice and an apology,” Gandhi asserted.

In the video, Gandhi is seen

Highlights

» A leaked paper led to a cancelled examination, a forced NEET re-exam and unbearable pressure on young minds, Gandhi said

» Behind every statistic is a child with a dream and a family now living with an irreplaceable loss, Gandhi said

cation system. Leaked papers. Cancelled exams. Years of preparation destroyed overnight. Our students are told to work honestly in a system that is not honest with them.

“The tears of parents who have lost their children, their wailing; there is no greater sorrow than this. This grief will live with them forever and along with it remain many questions about this broken and corrupt education system,” he had said in a post on X.

Referring to paper leaks and cancelled exams, he said, “Prime Minister has the audacity to talk about forgiving the students.”

“Has he even met a single grieving family who has lost their child, or those whose entire savings, life, time and dreams have been snatched away by paper leaks? The answer is no! India’s students do not need the Prime Minister’s forgiveness; Modi ji should apologise to them,” the Congress leader said.

interacting with the families of the students who committed suicide.

In Mamallapuram, interacting with the relatives of those who took the extreme step vis-a-vis NEET, Gandhi said, “Nothing is more painful than seeing a parent grieve their child.

“Behind every young life lost is a family carrying pain that will never leave them and serious questions about a broken edu-

RAM TEMPLE DONATION THEFT

Defending skit, slipper hurled at Pappu Yadav during presser

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A man threw a slipper at Independent MP Pappu Yadav during a press conference at his house on Sunday after the lawmaker defended his skit inside the Parliament House complex on the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple, leading to a scuffle between his supporters and the attacker.

Yadav was addressing the presser amid a row over his Friday protest with an FIR being filed in Varanasi against him, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and Samajwadi Party MP from Faizabad (Ayodhya) Awadhesh Prasad for allegedly hurting religious sentiments.

While Yadav was addressing the presser, a man questioned him over his actions and alleged that the MP had insulted Lord Ram. He then threw a slipper at Yadav and a scuffle ensued between the Purnia MP’s supporters and the attacker.

Yadav later alleged that it was an attempt on his life.



Independent MP Pappu Yadav addresses the media, in New Delhi, Sunday

PTI

According to police sources, the alleged attacker was identified as 34-year-old Sumit, a native of Uttar Pradesh’s Bulandshahr, who works in an iron fabrication business in Ghaziabad and has no previous criminal record.

The police source said that another man, identified as Happy, was present in an SUV parked outside Yadav’s residence when the incident occurred.

Investigators are verifying their claims and probing the motive behind the incident.

Rajesh Ranjan alias Pappu Yadav, dressed in a saffron out-

fit, performed the skit on Friday in the Parliament House complex along with other Opposition MPs in front of the Makar Dwar at the Parliament complex to protest the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

The MPs, including Rahul Gandhi, put money inside donation boxes, while Yadav slipped money into his pockets to symbolise the alleged theft at the Ram temple.

The BJP on Sunday accused Gandhi and Yadav of hurting Hindu sentiments and demanded that they publicly apologise.

However, a defiant Yadav said they were protesting to protect Sanatan and will not be forced down by any number of FIRs.

He was reacting a day after a case was filed in Varanasi on the complaint of seers against him, Gandhi and Samajwadi Party MP from Faizabad (Ayodhya) Awadhesh Prasad while BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj and other leaders filed a police complaint in Delhi.

SHIVAKUMAR LEADS ALL-PARTY MEET

Cauvery: CM affirms commitment to protect Karnataka’s interests

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Sunday asserted that his government was committed to protecting the interests of the state’s farmers and people on the Cauvery issue, while appealing to organisations to withdraw the proposed state-wide bandh.

He also said Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay has agreed to postpone his visit to Bengaluru following a request from the Karnataka government in view of the prevailing Cauvery water dispute, describing the gesture as one that would help maintain a cor-



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and former CM Siddaramaiah, in Bengaluru

PTI

dial atmosphere between the two states.

The two leaders were supposed to meet on Monday to discuss the Cauvery issue but Shivakumar had appealed to Vijay to defer his visit so as to hold talks in a more conducive atmosphere, as protests were

happening across the state over the inter-state dispute earlier this week.

Pro-Kannada organisations have given a call for Karnataka Bandh on August 13 against the Cauvery Water Management Authority’s order on Thursday upholding the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee’s order on releasing 3,500 cusecs of water for 15 days to Tamil Nadu.

Addressing reporters on Sunday after chairing an all-party meet on Cauvery, Shivakumar said there was no need for protests as rainfall had improved the situation and all political parties had extended support and such a bandh would not benefit anyone.

All involved in ‘chhanda chori’ part of BJP: Cong

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Sunday launched a scathing attack on the BJP over the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, saying not everyone in the BJP is a “chhanda chor” but all the “chhanda chors” are in the ruling party.

Senior Congress leader Pramod Tiwari claimed that the “theft” at the Ram Mandir was not limited to just the donations but it had begun as early as the time of the ‘Shila Pujan’.

“I hail from the Awadh region myself, and between 1985 and 1990, I served as the Tourism minister in the UP government. I have witnessed the Ram Janmabhoomi movement from very close quarters,” Tiwari said at a press confer-

Closer Look

» ‘Not everyone in the BJP is a chhanda chor but all the chhanda chors are in ruling party’

» The truth is that BJP did not build Ram Mandir; it was constructed following a Supreme Court order, Tiwari said

ence here.

“I am not saying that everyone in the BJP is a ‘chhanda chor,’ but all the ‘chhanda chors’ are in the BJP,” the Congress leader said.

“When the movement to build the Ram Mandir was underway, the slogan was: ‘Ram Lalla hum ayeenge,’ mandir wahin banayenge.’ Later, when the BJP formed the government in Uttar Pradesh, I asked when the temple would be built. The reply was: ‘When the BJP comes to power at the Centre as well,’ he said.

“When Atal Bihari Vajpay-

ee’s government was formed at the Centre, I asked the same question again. The reply was: ‘Just wait for now.’ The truth is this - The BJP never wanted the Ram Mandir to be built in Ayodhya; it only wanted to keep alive the Ram Mandir issue,” he alleged.

The truth is that the BJP did not build the Ram Mandir; it was constructed following a Supreme Court order, Tiwari said.

The Lok Sabha elections coincided with the time of the Ram Mandir’s construction, and for Prime Minister

Narendra Modi, the election was more important than the temple; consequently, he performed the consecration ceremony of an incomplete temple - an inauspicious act, Tiwari said.

The Shankaracharyas were not invited to the consecration ceremony, even though the rituals should have been performed by them, he said.

Prime Minister Modi took personal charge of the entire process, and every single member of the temple trust was appointed based on the his personal preference, Tiwari alleged.

“If Modi ji has claimed the credit for this, how can he absolve himself of the sins committed by the very people to whom he entrusted the responsibility?” he said.

Ranchi: Students continue protests over alleged JPSC, JSSC exam irregularities

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RANCHI: Hundreds of students continued their protest for the fifth consecutive day here on Sunday over alleged irregularities in the 14th JPSC examination, JSSC-CGL and other recruitment tests, demanding a CBI probe and reforms in the recruitment agencies.

The protesters, who have been holding an indefinite sit-in at a stadium since July 29, raised slogans such as ‘Order CBI probe in JPSC’, ‘Long live Students Unity’ and ‘Shame on Hemant Soren’.

“Paper leaks in JPSC have happened several times. This time, OMR sheets of candidates have been leaked. Chief Minister Hemant Soren has ordered a CID probe, but we are not satisfied,” JPSC aspirant Rahul Kumar Kranti said.

He alleged that previous probes into the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC)-CGL paper leak had not led to action and claimed that the latest investigation could also be “covered up” after a few months.

“We have completely lost faith in the ongoing CID probe. We demand a CBI probe into all recruitment examinations conducted by the JPSC and JSSC over the past seven years. We also demand the chief minister’s resignation on moral grounds,” Kranti said.

The protesters are demanding cancellation of the 14th JPSC Combined Preliminary Test held on April 19 and an independent probe by central agencies, including the CBI and Enforcement Directorate (ED), into alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations conducted by the JPSC and JSSC.

They are also demanding the introduction of a fifth option of “not attempted” in OMR sheets.

Over 26,000 govt primary schools shut in UP under BJP regime: Akhilesh

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: A day before the Uttar Pradesh Assembly’s Monsoon Session begins on August 3, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav mounted a broad attack on the Yogi Adityanath government, alleging failures in education, agriculture, employment and governance.

He said the Opposition would raise issues affecting the public and seek answers from the government during the session.

Addressing a press conference attended by senior party leaders, including Shival Singh Yadav and SP MLAs, Akhilesh released the fourth



Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav addresses a press conference, in Lucknow, Sunday

PTI

edition of the party’s “PDA audit”, focusing on the education sector.

He alleged that the government had shut or merged more than 26,000 government schools, resulting in a decline

of nearly 28 lakh student enrolments across the state.

Claiming that Dalit, backward and tribal children had suffered the most, Akhilesh said the closure of schools had adversely affected the education of children from poor families.

He also accused the government of weakening the public education system by reducing teaching staff instead of strengthening schools.

The SP chief alleged that the number of teachers had fallen by more than 62,000 while over 81,000 teaching posts remained vacant because the government had not undertaken fresh recruitment.

RAIPUR: Governor Ramen Dekha and Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Sunday attended the state-level programme of the ‘Nasha Mukta Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan’ at Lok Bhavan in Raipur, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi virtually launched the nationwide campaign from New Delhi.

Addressing the nation virtually, PM Modi said drug abuse affects not only individuals but also families and society.

He said the country’s youth have a vital role in achieving the goal of a developed India and urged them to channel their energy and talent towards nation-building by staying away from addiction. He also called



on young people to encourage their families, friends and communities to embrace a drug-free lifestyle.

Students, youth, representatives of educational institutions, voluntary organisations and youth groups participated in the programme and pledged to contribute to a drug-free India and raise awareness about the harmful effects of substance abuse.

The programme also high-

NCC organises 79-km cyclothon to mark 79 years of India’s Independence

The cyclothon was flagged off by Union Sports minister Mansukh Mandaviya

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A symbolic 79-km cyclothon, with riders largely consisting of 79 NCC cadets, was held here on Sunday to mark 79 years of India’s Independence, officials said.

The cyclothon was flagged off by Union Minister of Youth Affairs and Sports Mansukh Mandaviya in the presence of Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, boxer M C Mary Kom and former tennis player Leander Paes.

Director General, National Cadet Corps, Lt Gen Virendra Vats led the group of 79 NCC cadets in a symbolic 79-km ride to mark 79 years of India’s Independence, the defence ministry said in a statement.

The event commenced from Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium and concluded at the same venue after successfully covering the designated route through prominent landmarks of the national capital.

The initiative aimed to



inspire the youth to embrace fitness, environmental responsibility, and sustainable living while reinforcing the core values of patriotism, discipline, unity, and national service that form the foundation of the NCC, it said.

Organised under the theme

‘Clean India, Green India, Fit India,’ the cyclothon reaffirmed NCC’s commitment to national missions such as TB Mukta Bharat, Swachh Bharat, Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam and Har Ghar Tiranga, the ministry said.

The event encouraged participants and the public to adopt

cycling as an eco-friendly and sustainable mode of transport while promoting environmental conservation, reducing carbon emissions, and embracing healthy lifestyles, officials said.

Beyond being a sporting event, ‘NCC Cyclothon 2026’ served as a platform to cre-

Key Points

» The initiative aimed to inspire the youth to embrace fitness, environmental responsibility, and sustainable living

» ‘DG National Cadet Corps, Lt Gen Virendra Vats led the group of 79 NCC cadets in a symbolic 79-km ride to mark 79 years of India’s Independence’

ate awareness about physical fitness, environmental stewardship, road safety and responsible citizenship, they said.

The initiative inspired the youth to become ambassadors of positive social change by embracing discipline, teamwork, resilience, and community service, thereby contributing to the vision of a stronger, healthier, and greener India, the ministry said.

Nation Briefs

KERALA GOVT EXAMINING LEAVE CIRCULAR FOR DETAINED BJP COUNCILLOR: MINISTER

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala minister for Local Self Governments K M Shaji on Sunday said the department was seriously examining the issue of a purported government circular regarding the grant of leave to BJP councillor R Sugathan, who is under preventive detention. The circular, reportedly issued by the Home Department, stated that Sugathan could retain his councillorship if he submitted a leave application to the council and it was approved. Shaji said extending such a relief to a “criminal” was a serious matter. “We are taking it seriously and looking into it. A decision will be taken by Monday,” he told a television channel.

CONG, GFP BEGIN ALLIANCE TALKS FOR 2027 GOA POLLS; OPEN TO TIE-UP, SAYS AAP

PANAJI: Opposition parties Congress and the Goa Forward Party have launched preliminary talks to ally for the 2027 state Assembly polls, with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) also signalling its willingness for a tie-up. Talking to news agency on Sunday, Goa Pradesh Congress Committee president Girish Chodankar said he had held talks with Goa Forward Party (GFP) chief Vijai Sardesai on forming an alliance. The duo met in the Fatorda town of South Goa on Saturday. The Congress and GFP had fought the 2022 Goa Assembly polls together. Meanwhile, AAP Goa president Valmiki Naik on Saturday held a meeting with the party’s committee formed to decide on a tie-up with like-minded parties.

COPS BRUTALITY ROW

Paper leak protests: SC to hear pleas relating to police action today

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a batch of pleas alleging police brutality during the recent protests against irregularities in exams and the NEET paper leaks.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joy-malya Bagchi and V Mohana will be hearing the pleas in which the court had indicated that it might constitute an SIT headed by a former Supreme Court judge for a probe into the allegations made by protestors, pellet gun victims and to ascertain whether the attacks on policemen were carried out by students or some “miscreants”.

On July 28, the top court had restrained states from taking any coercive action against protesters and directed them to release those under 18 on the condition that none should have any criminal antecedents.

The top court had observed that a fair and independent probe in the matter was required and whosever committed excesses, took law into their hands should be taken to task. It had directed, “All states are hereby instructed to release children under the age of 18, who have been reported to be arrested or detained in connection with the ongoing protests and who do not possess any criminal antecedents.”

The top court had said if necessary, these children shall be released upon the execution of a simple bond by themselves or their family members, especially if such a requirement is insisted upon for surety.

It had taken note of allegations such as the use of pellet guns, lathis embedded with



Security personnel stop CJP supporters near Jantar Mantar FILE PIC

HIGHLIGHTS

» A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joy-malya Bagchi and V Mohana will be hearing the pleas

» The court had indicated that it might constitute an SIT headed by a former SC judge for a probe into the allegations made by protestors and pellet gun victims

tain the attacks on policemen and whether they were by students or some “miscreants”.

“Be that as it may, the allegations made by the petitioners, prima facie, establish a compelling case for an independent and impartial investigation into the incidents of violence. Such an investigation will adequately address the allegations presented by the family members of the police personnel, as well as the issues raised by the Solicitor General of India,” it said.

While posting the matter for further hearing, the top court had said in the interest of justice an opportunity was given to the Centre and the states concerned to place their versions on record before it considers constituting an independent committee or a SIT. The top court had issued notices to Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal and Kerala and asked their advocates general to appear online on the next date of hearing. It had issued a slew of interim directions to states where protests were held to preserve CCTV footage, drone recordings, body-camera footage, wireless communication records, PCR logs and other digital evidence pertaining to the protests.

Noting that the bench is mulling an independent, a transparent and thorough probe into all allegations by a task force, the bench had said a probe is also required to ascer-

nails, rubber bullets and electric batons on protestors resulting in severe life threatening injuries to several students and young women. The top court had directed that Delhi government and other states may proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered but no coercive measures shall be taken against the protesting students. “Such protection, nonetheless, shall not be extended to the persons with criminal antecedents,” it had clarified.

Nothing that the bench is mulling an independent, a transparent and thorough probe into all allegations by a task force, the bench had said a probe is also required to ascer-

Ladakh LG decentralises land-use approvals

LEH: In a significant move to decentralise decision-making and speed up development approvals, Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena has delegated powers to the Chief Secretary and the Divisional Commissioner to approve land-use proposals for development projects in areas outside municipal committees.

According to an official spokesperson, the initiative is part of the Union Territory’s ongoing pro-people deregulation drive aimed at promoting citizen-centric governance and easing procedural delays. Earlier, the Lieutenant Governor was the sole authority for approving all land-use change proposals outside municipal limits. Under the revised framework, the Divisional Commissioner has been authorised to approve land-use changes for plots measuring more than two kanals and up to four kanals, while the Chief Secretary will clear applications involving land parcels above four kanals and up to two acres. Proposals for land exceeding two acres will continue to require the Lieutenant Governor’s approval.

The move follows an earlier decision on July 8, under which residential, commercial, industrial and mixed-use development on plots up to two kanals was exempted from prior approval requirements.

Officials said the new framework addresses regulatory challenges arising from the absence of notified Master Plans and Zonal Development Plans in Ladakh, which had often delayed developmental projects and building permissions.

The interim mechanism is expected to provide relief to rural residents by enabling them to build houses, establish commercial establishments, undertake small-scale industrial activities and develop mixed-use properties without unnecessary procedural hurdles. The decision is expected to reduce compliance burdens and improve regulatory clarity.

MPOST

ATS, IB, MILITARY INTELLIGENCE JOIN PROBE

Paramedic student from Ayodhya under radar after bomb-making note recovery

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: Security agencies have intensified investigations after a handwritten note containing details related to bomb-making was recovered from a 26-year-old paramedical student at Rajarshi Dashrath Autonomous State Medical College in Ayodhya.

The student’s mobile phone and laptop have been seized and sent for forensic examination after investigators found social media videos and internet searches related to explosives, according to sources.

The student, a resident of Balrampur district, was pursuing an X-ray technician course at the medical college after enrolling in October 2025. He was taken into custody on Saturday after a handwritten note detailing the process of making explosives, along with

INSIGHT

» The student, a resident of Balrampur district, was pursuing an X-ray technician course at a

medical college

» The student’s mobile phone and laptop have been seized and sent for forensic examination

references to chemicals and explosive devices, was found inside the X-ray section of the college. Police also sealed the student’s rented accommodation near the college. Multiple agencies, including the ATS, IB, Military Intelligence and Local Intelligence Unit (LIU), joined the probe after the recovery.

According to sources, investigators examining the student’s mobile phone found several Instagram reels related to making and detonating bombs. His internet search history allegedly contained queries related to explosives and methods of carrying out blasts. The mobile phone and other digital devices

have been sent for forensic analysis to determine the origin of the material and whether it was merely accessed online or linked to any larger conspiracy.

Security agencies are also scrutinising the student’s social media activity, online chats and digital contacts. Investigators are trying to establish whether he had any links with extremist networks or had come under the influence of radical content circulated through social media. Officials, however, said no evidence has so far emerged to indicate his association with any banned organisation or terror outfit. Sources said agencies are examining every possible

angle, including the possibility of online radicalisation. They are also verifying whether the student was in contact with any suspicious individuals or digital networks.

Officials stressed that no conclusions would be drawn until the forensic examination and questioning are completed.

Investigators are also gathering information about the student’s movements inside the medical college and the people he frequently interacted with. His family background and recent activities are also being verified as part of the probe.

During questioning, the student reportedly claimed that he had written the details after watching a film with fellow students in which bomb-making was depicted. He told investigators that he copied the information onto paper out of curiosity. Police are verifying this claim.

IAF concludes week-long drill in Pokhran

MPOST BUREAU

JAISALMER: The Indian Air Force (IAF) on Sunday concluded its week-long exercise at the Pokhran Field Firing Range, showcasing its combat readiness and counter-drone warfare capabilities, officials said. According to defence sources in Rajasthan, the exercise, Rotor Clapp-III, was conducted on the theme of ‘Counter Unmanned Aerial Systems (Counter-UAS)’.

Multiple helicopter units of the IAF took part in it.

The primary objective of the drill was to test operational concepts against emerging aerial threats and strengthen combat preparedness in an evolving battlefield environment, sources said.

The exercise focused on enhancing the operational capabilities of the IAF’s helicopter fleet to counter growing threats posed by unmanned aerial systems (UAS). It also assessed strategies, techniques and procedures for integrated helicopter operations under simulated real combat conditions.

Almost all major helicopter platforms of the IAF participated and demonstrated their combat capabilities through a series of tactical missions.

These included precision strikes, battlefield support, reconnaissance, troop insertion, casualty evacuation and coordinated operations to counter both aerial and ground-based threats, sources said.

MENDHAR/JAMMU: At least two houses and a school building were completely damaged, and more than six other houses developed cracks after a severe land subsidence occurred in a remote mountain village in Jammu and Kashmir’s Poonch district, officials said on Sunday.

The land in Saroti Jabran village reportedly began sinking following heavy rains on July 22. Over the past 11 days, the situation has deteriorated, forcing several families to abandon their homes as large cracks continued to widen across the affected area, officials said.

Tehsildar Mendhar Rahul Basotra confirmed the damage in the village and added that over a dozen houses remain

At least 2 houses and a school building completely damaged

under threat as the ground continues to show signs of instability.

Basotra said he, along with field staff, was in touch with the affected families and was monitoring the situation, adding that a detailed assessment of the damage was underway.

The residents said at least five residential houses and two school buildings have already been destroyed, with several other houses suffering cracks, prompting the inhabitants to shift to safer locations.

Lightning strikes kill 5 in J’khand

RAMGARH/GODDA: Five women were killed and four others injured in lightning strikes in Jharkhand’s Ramgarh and Godda districts on Sunday, police said.

Of the five fatalities, three were reported from Patraru Block in Ramgarh, and two from Maheshpur-Rampur village in Basantrai Block in Godda district, officers said.

All the victims were killed while sowing paddy in the fields, he said.

“Three women were killed in lightning strikes in two villages of Ramgarh. They were identified as Rekha Devi (45) and Roshni Kumari (21), both from Sakul village, and Sushanti Devi (34), a resident of Palani village,” Patraru Police Station officer-in-charge Shivalal Kumar Gupta said.

The identities of the two women killed in Godda are yet to be ascertained.

MPOST

‘Land subsidence’ hits remote village in J&K Poonch: Officials

The subsidence has also severely damaged essential infrastructure, disrupting drinking water supply and electricity after pipelines, power lines and poles were damaged, Syed Zulfkar Hussain Shah, a local said.

He appealed for an urgent geological assessment and engineering intervention to divert the accumulating water, which locals believe is triggering the land movement.

Shah warned that a shrine, a graveyard and another residential settlement located downhill were also under threat if the subsidence continues.

Another resident alleged that despite the worsening crisis, no senior government officials had visited the remote village.

AGENCIES

Punjab’s Mann govt has failed to deliver: Saini

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday launched a sharp attack on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in Punjab, alleging that Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann was “entertaining people with jokes and rhetoric” instead of focusing on governance and public welfare.

Addressing a ‘Vimukt Jati Samaj’ Sannam in Punjab’s Faridkot, Saini claimed that the Punjab government had failed to fulfil its primary responsibility of working in the interest of the people. He asserted that people from Punjab who meet him in Chandigarh often express a desire for governance reforms similar to those implemented by the BJP government in Haryana.

Saini also expressed confidence that the BJP would emerge victorious in the Punjab Assembly elections, due early



Haryana CM Nayab Saini during 'Vimukt Jati Samaj' Sannam in Punjab's Faridkot

next year, claiming that voters had made up their minds to support the party.

Highlighting the BJP government’s policies in Haryana, Saini said that immediately after assuming office, the state Cabinet approved a 10 per cent reservation for the Deprived Scheduled Caste (DSC) community. He alleged that, in contrast, the reservation quota for the community was being withdrawn in Punjab.

He further claimed that

despite clearing the selection process and medical examinations, several DSC candidates in Punjab were denied appointments at the time of joining. Saini said that if the BJP formed the next government in Punjab, the benefits of reservation for the DSC community would be restored.

Targeting both the ruling AAP and the Congress, Saini alleged that years of neglect under successive governments had deprived the people of Punjab of better governance and welfare measures. He maintained that Punjab could benefit from policies similar to those implemented in Haryana.

The Haryana Chief Minister said his government had provided jobs to 604 DSC candidates as part of the recruitment of 5,600 police personnel under the reservation policy.

Referring to the recent recruitment of excise inspec-

tors in Punjab, Saini alleged that the exercise exposed irregularities in the state’s recruitment process. He claimed that candidates who had written unusual entries alongside their names were selected and noted that the Punjab and Haryana High Court had stayed the recruitment results. Alleging that jobs were being “sold” in Punjab, he accused the state government of betraying unemployed youth.

Saini also questioned the AAP government’s record on fulfilling its election promises. He said the BJP had fulfilled 70 of the 217 promises made before the 2024 Haryana Assembly elections during its one-and-a-half-year tenure. In contrast, he asked Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal how many of the 57 promises made before the 2022 Punjab Assembly elections had been implemented.

MPOST

Punjab CM inaugurates two new ‘Schools of Eminence’ in Ludhiana

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday dedicated two new ‘Schools of Eminence’ at Kidwai Nagar and Miller Ganj in Ludhiana, taking the district’s tally to 16 such schools.

The new campuses, equipped with modern classrooms, state-of-the-art laboratories, an auditorium and other advanced facilities, are part of the Punjab government’s ongoing efforts to strengthen public education and provide world-class learning infrastructure to students, he said.

Asserting that sustained investment in education has transformed government schools into institutions of excellence, Mann said improved infrastructure, overseas teacher training and mod-



ern teaching practices have led to a growing preference for government schools among parents.

Mann also spent some time interacting with students during his visit to the newly inaugurated schools.

He visited classrooms, science laboratories and other academic facilities, where he took stock of the modern infra-

structure and interacted with students about their studies, scientific experiments and learning experience.

Addressing a gathering, Mann said that after leading Punjab’s industrial revolution, Ludhiana is now emerging as a frontrunner in the state’s education revolution.

The ‘School of Eminence’ model has been instrumental in reducing the gap between the rich and the poor in access to quality education. Today, children from ordinary families are receiving facilities that are even better than those available in many private schools, he said. The school at Kidwai Nagar has been completed at a cost of Rs 10.62 crore, while the school at Miller Ganj has been completed at a cost of Rs 3.48 crore.

MPOST

Examination irregularities: Around 158 CBI cases awaiting trial in courts

‘Some of these pending cases registered more than two decades ago’

NEW DELHI: Around 158 cases linked to alleged recruitment examination irregularities are awaiting the start of trial in various courts in the country despite the completion of CBI investigations, with some of them registered more than two decades ago, sources said.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has decided to approach all high courts to transfer these pending cases to the fast-track courts, which are being set up in various states to handle cases under the new anti-paper leak law, they said.

Sources said the CBI has decided to convey to the high courts that it will provide dedicated special prosecutors to conduct these trials and make all possible resources available so that they are concluded at the earliest possible.

In the national capital, there are around 25 cases since 2000 that are awaiting trial despite the completion of CBI investigation. These include the AIIMS PG recruitment examination of 2010-11, Delhi Uni-

KEY POINTS

» The CBI has decided to approach HCs to transfer these cases to the fast-track courts, which are being set up in various states to handle cases under the new anti-paper leak law

» In the national capital, there are around 25 cases since 2000 that are awaiting trial despite the completion of CBI investigation



» Bihar has five pending cases, including three related to the alleged paper leak of NEET 2024, besides irregularities in the PMT (pre-medical test) of 2003 and 2011

versity Medical and Dental Entrance of 2011, CAT (common admission test) irregularities of 2004, SSC (staff selection commission) recruitment of 2013, and teachers’ recruitment, sources said.

Bihar has five pending cases, including three related to the alleged paper leak of NEET 2024, besides irregularities in the PMT (pre-medical test) of 2003 and 2011, they said.

In Himachal Pradesh, the constable recruitment case of 2022 is among the three cases awaiting start of trial. In Jammu and Kashmir, three cases are awaiting trial, which include irregularities in junior engineer and constable recruitment, they said. Similarly, five cases are awaiting trial in Jharkhand; five in Karnataka; three in Maharashtra, including two cases related to NEET

Haryana: Hooda congratulates CWG medallists

CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhopinder Singh Hooda on Sunday congratulated Indian athletes for their medal-winning performances at the Commonwealth Games, saying Haryana’s sportspersons had once again brought glory to the country.

He said the achievements reflected the sports policy, infrastructure and academies established during the Congress government, which transformed Haryana into a sports hub and encouraged young talent. Hooda alleged that the BJP government had weakened the sports policy, depriving athletes of due rewards, honours, appointments and promotions. He claimed several international medallists were yet to receive high-ranking government posts, while athletes appointed as DSPs during the Congress regime had not been promoted.

He demanded that all Commonwealth Games medallists be immediately appointed to senior positions, including DSPs.

MPOST

Nation Briefs

BHARAT SCOUTS CHIEF RECEIVES TOP MALAYSIAN SCOUT HONOUR

CHANDIGARH: Chief National Commissioner of the Bharat Scouts and Guides Krishana Kumar Khandelwal has been conferred the Bintang Semangat Rimba Emas (Gold Star of the Forest Spirit) by the Governor of Melaka, Malaysia, Tun Seri Setia Haji Mohd Ali bin Mohd Rustam. The award, regarded as the third-highest Scout honour in Malaysia.



NFR CANCELS, RESCHEDULES TRAINS AMID TRACK RESTORATION WORK

MALIGAON: Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) has announced the cancellation, rescheduling and regulation of several trains as restoration work continues near New Harangajao station following the settlement of tracks on Lines 1 and 2. Train services on the Lumding-Badarpur Hill Section are currently operating through Line 3 with enhanced safety measures. Four trains, including the Guwahati-Dullabcherra and Guwahati-Silchar Express services, have been cancelled, while eight others, including the Agartala-Narangi, Guwahati-Sairang and Agartala-Anand Vihar Tejas Express, have been rescheduled. Two trains, including the Kolkata-Agartala Garib Rath Express, will be regulated en route.



EDITORIAL

PROXY
BATTLEGROUND

What appears, at first glance, to be a bewildering series of disconnected attacks—from Houthi strikes on Saudi oil facilities and drone attacks on ships in Egypt to missile launches towards Jordan and American-Saudi air raids in Iraq—is, in reality, part of a single geopolitical confrontation whose centre lies in the Strait of Hormuz. The conflict between the United States and Iran has evolved into a regional contest fought through proxies, strategic waterways and allied states rather than through conventional direct confrontation alone. Every new strike opens another theatre, drawing more actors into an increasingly volatile security architecture. The danger is no longer limited to military escalation between Washington and Tehran; it now encompasses the stability of global energy markets, international shipping, regional diplomacy and the fragile political balances within several Middle Eastern states. The multiplication of battlefronts is not evidence of chaos but of a deliberate strategy in which Iran projects influence through allied militias and armed movements, while the United States relies on its network of regional partners to contain Tehran's ambitions. The result is a conflict that has become geographically fragmented but strategically interconnected, making de-escalation exponentially more difficult with every passing week.

At the heart of this confrontation lies the Strait of Hormuz, arguably the world's most consequential maritime chokepoint. Before hostilities intensified, nearly one-fifth of globally traded oil and liquefied natural gas moved through this narrow waterway linking the Persian Gulf to international markets. Control over Hormuz has always represented both an economic and military lever for Iran, but the present conflict has transformed that leverage into an active battlefield. Tehran's efforts to disrupt shipping and assert control over alternative navigation routes challenge the long-standing international principle of freedom of navigation, prompting repeated American military responses. Yet each US strike produces predictable retaliation against American military installations and allies in Jordan, Kuwait and elsewhere, creating a cycle in which deterrence no longer functions as intended. Rather than compelling negotiations over sanctions or regional security, military exchanges have reinforced mutual distrust and undermined previous diplomatic efforts. The collapse of interim understandings has hardened positions, suggesting that Iran now views strategic control over maritime access as more valuable than immediate sanctions relief. This evolution marks an important shift in Iranian calculations. Instead of merely surviving international isolation, Tehran appears intent on reshaping the regional balance by demonstrating that any attempt to isolate Iran economically will inevitably impose costs on the global economy itself.

The widening role of Iran's regional allies further illustrates how today's Middle Eastern conflicts are increasingly networked. The Houthis' declaration of a blockade targeting Saudi Arabia has effectively linked the Strait of Hormuz crisis with another vital maritime artery—the Bab el-Mandeb Strait and the Red Sea, gateways to the Suez Canal. By threatening shipping through these waters and targeting Saudi oil infrastructure, the Houthis have transformed a local Yemeni conflict into a strategic extension of Iran's regional pressure campaign. The consequences extend far beyond the Gulf. Shipping companies are already rerouting vessels, insurance premiums are climbing, transit volumes through critical sea lanes are falling, and energy markets remain vulnerable to sudden disruptions. Simultaneously, Iraq has emerged as another dangerous flashpoint. Saudi accusations against Iran-backed militias, followed by joint American-Saudi airstrikes, underscore Baghdad's increasingly precarious position. Iraq finds itself trapped between two indispensable partners—the United States, whose military presence continues to shape its security landscape, and Iran, whose political and militia networks exercise substantial influence across the country. The Iraqi government's long-term objective of integrating or disarming autonomous militias risks becoming unattainable if regional confrontation continues to intensify. Every external strike weakens Baghdad's authority while strengthening armed factions that thrive in conditions of perpetual instability.

The attack on Egypt's Damietta port offers perhaps the clearest warning that the conflict is no longer confined to its original participants. Egypt has carefully avoided direct military involvement, preferring instead to act as a mediator in regional crises while safeguarding its own economic interests, particularly revenues from the Suez Canal. An attack on vessels operating from an Egyptian port therefore represents more than another isolated act of sabotage; it signals that even countries attempting to remain neutral may find themselves drawn into the conflict simply because of their strategic geography. Equally concerning is the uncertain future of Israel's northern front. Although the ceasefire with Hezbollah has largely held, it remains exceptionally fragile. The planned withdrawal of Israeli forces from southern Lebanon and the proposed disarmament of Hezbollah remain deeply contested issues capable of collapsing under the weight of any renewed provocation. A single missile exchange between Israel, Hezbollah or Iran could rapidly undo months of uneasy calm and reopen another major theatre of conflict. This constant risk of horizontal escalation is what distinguishes the present crisis from earlier regional confrontations. Instead of one front expanding vertically through greater military intensity, multiple fronts are expanding simultaneously, multiplying opportunities for miscalculation and making diplomatic crisis management considerably more complex.

The international community can no longer afford to view these developments as separate security incidents requiring isolated responses. They represent components of a broader regional transformation in which maritime security, energy infrastructure, proxy warfare and geopolitical rivalry have become inseparable. Every disruption in the Strait of Hormuz reverberates through the Red Sea; every strike in Iraq influences Gulf security; every attack on commercial shipping affects inflation, energy prices and economic stability worldwide.

PART I



ANIRBAN GANGULY

THE WRITER IS A MEMBER OF THE NATIONAL EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE (NEC), BJP, AND THE CHAIRMAN OF DR SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE RESEARCH FOUNDATION

The real test of patriotic dissent is not the volume of its slogans but its commitment to constitutional methods, civic duty and national unity

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A VETERAN JOURNALIST AND COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

India's economic success (or the lack of it) will ultimately be judged not by a record or superlative increase in stock market indices, but by whether ordinary Indian households continue to believe that disciplined saving still pays

Abuse is not Awakening

India cannot become a Viswaguru through abuse, threats and constitutional defiance. Its rise must rest on duty, discipline and nation-building

Sonam Wangchuk is on his way to Ladakh, and by the time this column appears, he will be back in his familiar surroundings, recuperating and working on his future projects. One wishes him well. As far as his demands and concerns went, they have been taken cognisance of, and the assurances conveyed to him by senior ministers and leaders of PM Modi's government have been fulfilled. PM Modi's approach has always been solution-driven, accountable and sensitive. With the passage of the anti-paper leak legislation, his government has done what no other government or party was willing to do over the last fifty years.

Wangchuk's close associate, Gitanjali Wangchuk, is, we are told, a devotee of Sri Aurobindo. In her parting shot, she is said to have observed that it is Gen Z that has shown what it means for India to be a Viswaguru and that they have lived the Sanatana Dharma. Well, one needs to make a distinction between the actual Gen Z and the counterfeit Gen Z. That is a distinction most have not made or have refused to make. Let me also put on record here that Sri Aurobindo was always against any kind of fasting, whether for political or spiritual objectives. His writings, conversations and talks make that amply clear to anyone who has cared to read them seriously.

Those who abused Modi displayed cowardice and hate instead of courage without hate. They displayed weakness disguised by threats of violence instead of strength without violence. They demonstrated false patriotism without an iota of conscience and insisted on rights before even cultivating a sense of duty. Are they the real Gen Z? Any genuine reader or follower of Sri Aurobindo, Swami Vivekananda or Mahatma Gandhi would agree that any attempt to cultivate national greatness while standing only on the stilts of rights, devoid of a binding sense of duty—kartavya—is bound to collapse.



Abuse, expletives and calls to anarchy cannot define the path of a nation aspiring to become a Viswaguru

Can those who abuse Narendra Modi, hurling the most abominable expletives at him and his deceased mother, who herself embodied pure motherhood and radiated dignity and compassion, aspire to make India a Viswaguru? Is the path leading India to become a Viswaguru to be defined and paved by abuse, expletives and calls to anarchy? Is India to become a Viswaguru by following the "Grammar of Anarchy", as Babasaheb Ambedkar termed it, or by resorting to what Sri Aurobindo called "Goonda-raj"?

As early as 1935, in answer to a disciple's query on whether he definitely foresaw a free India, Sri Aurobindo replied that India's freedom was settled and was a "question of working out only". The larger question was: "What is

India going to do with her independence? Bolshevism? Goonda-raj?"

It is only the proponents of "Goonda-raj" who hurl despicable abuses at a thrice-elected Prime Minister and his deceased mother, and call for his death. Can these types seriously educate us on how India can become a Viswaguru? Even those who supported them from various vantage points never condemned that string of horrible abuses. Far from living Sanatana Dharma, those who abused Narendra Modi and his deceased mother had not an iota of the essence or core values of Sanatana Dharma.

Leave aside living or understanding Sanatana Dharma; these chanters of "death to Modi" have a strong aversion to Sanatana Dharma. They wish to eradicate Sanatana Dharma. They see Sanatana Dharma as a hindrance to the India they want to create. How can negators of Sanatana Dharma be

the harbingers of India as a Viswaguru?

Would they accept, for instance, Sri Aurobindo's Uttarpara Speech, in which he speaks of his communion with Sri Krishna in the infamous Lalbazar lock-up in Kolkata after his arrest in 1908? Would the following description be acceptable to them: "He placed the Gita in my hands. His strength entered into me and I was able to do the sadhan of the Gita. I was not only to understand intellectually but to realise what Sri Krishna demanded of Arjuna and what He demands of those who aspire to do His work... I realised what the Hindu religion meant"? Or would they say that Sri Aurobindo, then Aurobindo Ghose, was certainly under the influence of psychedelics?

Would they agree with Sri Aurobindo's agenda and prognosis when he concludes: "When therefore it is said that India shall rise, it is the Sanatana Dharma that shall rise. When it is said that India shall be great, it is the Sanatana Dharma that shall be great. When it is said that India shall expand and extend herself, it is the Sanatana Dharma that shall expand and extend itself over the world. It is for the dharma and by the dharma that India exists"? Or would they agree with his programme for national regeneration when he says "that it is the Sanatana Dharma which for us is nationalism. This Hindu nation was born with the Sanatana Dharma, with it it moves and with it it grows. When the Sanatana Dharma declines, then the nation declines, and if the Sanatana Dharma were capable of perishing, with the Sanatana Dharma it would perish. Sanatana Dharma, that is nationalism"? This Sri Aurobindo certainly has no takers among the Modi abusers.

....to be continued tomorrow!
Views expressed are personal

India's Orphaned Saver

Markets are unstable, FD rates are falling and traditional investment wisdom is faltering, leaving everyday Indians wondering where their savings are truly safe

"The essence of investment management is always the management of risks, not the management of profit."
— Benjamin Graham

For India's middle-class, the compass has been broken. For decades, they lived by a simple financial creed. Work hard. Save diligently. Avoid unnecessary debt. Spread your investments. Stay invested for the long term. Wealth, fathers and grandmothers assured them, would follow patience rather than speculation. The advice served many generations well. But today, that same remit seems to have lost its bearings, its innards drilled into and hollowed out by whiplashes that are too unpredictable to be decipherable to most.

Every morning brings news capable of unsettling financial markets before the first cup of tea is finished. A missile strike happens again in West Asia, fresh tariff threats are given air by some very familiar people in Washington, growth slows down further in Europe, manufacturing weakens in China or oil prices go volatile. Any or all of these events unfolding thousands of kilometres away influence the value of an Indian family's lifetime savings instantly.

Crores of investors find themselves looking down the barrel of a gun that may fire at any moment. The uncertainty is not about whether markets will rise or fall in the near future. It is about whether there remains any place where hard-earned savings can dare hope to grow without constant anxiety. That is why today's Indian saver feels strangely orphaned, perhaps for the first time in decades.

No Safe Harbour

Investment cycles have always existed. Equities rise and correct. Interest rates move up and down. Gold shines in uncertain times before cooling off again. But what makes today unusual is that almost every traditional avenue appears to be under pressure simultaneously. Equity markets have become hostage to global sentiment as much as domestic fundamentals. Balanced and hybrid mutual funds, once marketed as the ideal middle path between safety and growth, have struggled



When returns appear uncertain despite years of responsible financial behaviour, confidence begins to erode

whenever markets have turned sharply uneasy. Debt funds have their own limitations. Real estate remains prohibitively expensive for the middle-class, while gold becomes attractive only after prices have already surged.

In ordinarily times, investors would retreat to the reassuring familiarity of fixed deposits. They may not generate spectacular returns, but they preserve capital and offer peace of mind. But even that refuge is becoming less comforting. As inflation moderates and interest rates soften, banks have trimmed FD rates. For retirees, pensioners and conservative households, the mathematics is becoming uncomfortable. The objective is no longer earning attractive returns; it is preserving purchasing power.

Diversification, long regarded as the golden rule of investing, suddenly appears less reassuring when every asset class seems to disappoint in its own way.

India's New Reality

The scale of India's financial transformation partly explains this new reality. India now has more than 24 crore demat accounts, monthly Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) inflows exceed Rs 25,000 crore and foreign institutional investors move tens of thousands of crores into or out of India within days. Household financial savings have shifted from physical assets such as gold and property towards market-linked instru-

ments. This deepening of financial participation is healthy, but it also means that global volatility reaches Indian households far more quickly than it did 15 or 20 years ago.

Household financial savings, once exceeding 11 per cent of GDP, have moderated in recent years even as household debt has climbed. That combination of a declining savings cushion alongside rising financial commitments should concern policymakers as much as market participants. A nation cannot build sustained economic resilience if its most disciplined savers begin to lose faith in the very system they were encouraged to embrace.

A Different India

Many recall the global financial crisis of 2008 and ask why India appears more vulnerable today. The answer lies not in economic weakness but in economic evolution. 20 years ago, India was considerably less integrated with global financial markets. Domestic consumption provided a powerful cushion, foreign participation in Indian equities was lower and global shocks travelled more slowly into household finances. Today's India is very different.

As mentioned, foreign investors move billions of dollars in and out of markets within hours. Incredibly sophisticated algorithms amplify every geopolitical headline. Global supply chains, commodity prices and currency movements are inter-

twined in ways unimaginable two decades ago. A conflict in the Gulf influences crude prices. Crude prices shape inflation expectations. Inflation affects interest rates. Interest rates influence corporate earnings. And earnings determine stock valuations.

Paradoxically, this same interconnectedness has benefited India by attracting investment, expanding capital markets and financing economic growth. But integration carries in its tail an unavoidable price – volatility imported from abroad. The same openness that fuels prosperity during good times also transmits uncertainty during difficult ones.

Confidence Deficit

None of this implies that regulators or governments can (or should) prevent market corrections. Financial markets are not designed to offer guaranteed returns, nor can policymakers shield investors from every geopolitical tremor. Indeed, India's macroeconomic fundamentals remain stronger than comparable economies. Inflation has broadly remained under control, the banking system is healthier than it was a decade ago, foreign exchange reserves provide an important buffer and the Reserve Bank of India has balanced growth and price stability with considerable prudence.

Yet, a distinction must be drawn between macroeconomic stability and household confidence. The average investor does

not analyse bond yields or fiscal deficits. He judges the economy through the performance of his retirement corpus, his children's education fund or the monthly income generated by decades of disciplined savings.

When those aspirations appear uncertain despite years of responsible financial behaviour, confidence begins to erode. Confidence, unlike capital, cannot be restored overnight.

Beyond Returns

India has rightly celebrated the democratisation of investing. As financial literacy has improved, crores of people now invest through systematic investment plans. Households have gradually moved beyond physical assets towards financial ones. These are welcome transformations that deserve to continue. But the next phase of India's financial journey cannot be measured merely by the number of demat accounts opened or the amount flowing into mutual funds every month. It must also be measured by something less tangible but infinitely more valuable: trust.

Ordinary savers do not seek extraordinary wealth. They seek predictability. They want confidence that disciplined investing will still reward discipline; that prudence will not become a handicap; and that long-term planning remains worthwhile despite short-term turbulence. Markets will recover, as they always have. Interest-rate cycles will reverse. Geopolitical crises will eventually subside.

The larger question is whether confidence will recover just as easily. Because an economy ultimately runs not on the wealth of its richest investors, but in the confidence of its ordinary savers. Once that confidence begins to erode, rebuilding it takes far longer than recovering a stock market index. If India's saver begins to feel orphaned, the consequences will extend far beyond investment portfolios. They will be felt in consumption, entrepreneurship, retirement planning and in the confidence with which an entire nation looks towards its economic future. That would be sad. And downright deadly.

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CLAIMS MIDEAST ALLIES HAVE REACHED THE PARAMETERS OF A DEAL

Trump: US will order halt to Iran strikes amid deal talks in Mideast

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump says he will order American forces to hold off on new strikes against Iran, claiming Mideast allies have reached the parameters of a deal to end the 5-month old war.

The emerging deal “would include the Immediate, Complete, and Total OPENING OF THE HORMUZ STRAIT, and an end to Iran’s nuclear threat,” Trump wrote in a Saturday evening social media post.

“Based on this request, I have agreed, for the future benefit of the WORLD and, likewise, the survival of a successful and prosperous Iran, to cancel the attack, subject to being able to rapidly make a DEAL,” Trump said.

However, Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on Sunday that the Strait of Hormuz “will in no way return to the status it was before February 28th,” the day the war started.

On a call with Iranian state TV, he added that Iran is discussing shipping through the strait with Oman, on the other side of Hormuz, but that there’s no current talk about reopening the crucial waterway.

Trump has announced halts to strikes in Iran on several occasions since the United States and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, only for things to unravel and fighting to resume again.

Iran’s defence minister



The latest proposal would bring sides back to negotiating table

Highlights

» Saudis concerned about Iran retaliation

» On Thursday, Trump also announced a disarmament deal with Hamas in Gaza

» Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, the kingdom’s de facto leader, spoke with Trump

said on X that the country was “neither surprised nor passive” following Trump’s announcement and said Iran continues to remain alert in the face of concrete threats from the US.

While Iran’s leaders appear united in a war strategy signalling strength and endurance, a struggle for control seems to be brewing within the theocracy’s leadership between those who oppose all negotiations with the US and others who count on military pressure to win at

the negotiating table.

A regional official says the proposal announced by Trump over the weekend calls for the US and Iran to return to negotiations and continue working out many of the issues that have stymied prior progress on the deal.

The official, who is involved in the mediation efforts, said the proposal calls for reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and halting attacks

across the region, including by Iranian-backed militias in Iraq on the Arab Gulf countries and Jordan.

The US, in exchange, will end its naval blockade on Iran and allow Tehran to export its oil as stated in the tentative ceasefire deal, he said.

No deal has been reached yet, but mediation efforts are underway, said the official, who spoke on condition of anonymity because he wasn’t authorised to talk to the media.

Trump said that Israel is joining his commitment to end the war by implementing the ceasefire deal. Israel did not publicly comment on the announcement.

On Thursday, Trump also announced a disarmament deal with Hamas in Gaza. But on Sunday, an Israeli official told The Associated Press that Israel has shared “serious security concerns” with the White House about it.

Meanwhile, Palestinians are reporting an increase in the scale of Israeli strikes across the enclave, with at least 17 people killed overnight and through Sunday evening, Israel’s military said the strikes targeted militants.

Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, the kingdom’s de facto leader, spoke with Trump by phone Saturday and raised concerns about the US potentially escalating the conflict with Iran, according to the Saudi press agency.

The Saudis, according to a person briefed on the substance of the call but not authorised to comment publicly, are concerned that Tehran could respond with attacks on the energy infrastructure of the kingdom and other Gulf countries.

The call happened before Trump’s social media announcement, the person said.

Blaze on Indonesian ferry leaves at least 5 dead, dozens missing

SURABAYA: An Indonesian ferry carrying 271 people caught fire in waters off the main island of Java on Sunday, leaving at least five people dead and dozens missing as rescuers and passing vessels evacuated hundreds from the burning ship, officials said.

The Mutiara Sentosa 2 ferry was travelling from Indonesia’s second-largest city of Surabaya in East Java to the city of Makassar in South Sulawesi, with 232 passengers and 39 crew members, when the fire broke out between 6 am and 7 am in waters off Sumenep regency, according to Indonesia’s National Search and Rescue Agency, or Basarnas.

The ferry operator, PT Atosim Lampung Pelayaran, reported the incident to the Surabaya search and rescue office about an hour later, Basarnas said in a statement.



Smoke billows from passenger ship after it caught fire in the waters off Madura Island of Indonesia

It said the company received information from the ferry’s captain that the vessel was on fire near the northern tip of Madura island, but contact was later lost.

By 9:45 am, authorities determined the ferry was

about 19 nautical miles north of Buruan Sapudi island after communicating with the nearby cargo vessel Meratus Project 3, which was unable to approach the burning vessel closely because it was carrying a flammable load.

Israel says it has serious concerns with Hamas disarmament deal

TEL AVIV: Israel has shared “serious security concerns” with the White House regarding the proposed disarmament deal with Hamas, an Israeli official told The Associated Press on Sunday.

Doron Spielman, spokesperson for the Israeli PM’s office, told the AP that Israel’s intelligence assessment is that Hamas remains committed to rebuilding its military rather than genuinely demilitarising. He said the Israeli military would not withdraw

from Gaza — where it controls more than 60 per cent of the territory — before Hamas disarms.

“Our assessment is that if we redeploy before Hamas is truly disarmed, it will quickly expand its presence throughout Gaza, rebuild its terrorist infrastructure, once again threaten Israeli communities, and seek to carry out another Oct 7-style attack,” he said, referring to the attack in 2023 that triggered Israel’s war in Gaza.

Ukrainian drones kill 5 in Russia

MOSCOW: Ukrainian drone strikes killed at least five people across Russia, also hitting industrial sites and a further warehouse belonging to Russia’s e-commerce giant Wildberries, local officials said.

Wildberries, Russia’s largest online marketplace, is sometimes described as the country’s answer to Amazon. In under two weeks, Ukraine has struck over a dozen of the retailer’s depots, part of Kyiv’s aerial campaign aimed at undermining Moscow’s war effort, hurting its economy and making people feel the consequences of the Kremlin’s all-out invasion of Ukraine.

Russian air defences overnight shot down 635 Ukrainian drones, including over occupied Crimea and the Black and Azov Seas, according to the Defense Ministry in Moscow. The ministry did not say how many were launched or struck targets.

Meanwhile, Russia attacked Ukraine with 133 drones during the night, 24 of which hit targets, according to the Ukrainian air force. Later on Sunday, separate Russian attacks on the Ukrainian cities of Zaporizhzhia and Kharkiv killed at least two people, according to local officials.

Ukrainian drones targeted a Wildberries warehouse in the Samara region, some 800 kilometres (500 miles) from the Russian-Ukrainian border, according to local Gov Vyacheslav Fedorishchev. He said a fire had broken out but there were no casualties.

Kyiv’s campaign against Wildberries first hit the company’s sites in Elektrostal, just east of Moscow, and in the Tambov region July 18. Strikes followed on facilities across western and southern Russia, as well as Russian-held Crimea. At least nine people have been killed and scores wounded.

Ceuta grapples with aftermath of border surge after most migrants leave Spanish territory

At least 72 migrants died while crossing the breakwater barrier

CEUTA: Ceuta over the weekend no longer looked like a city on edge, but the events of the week were still on everyone’s minds.

Most of the 60,000 migrants who swam, scrambled and later charged into the tiny Spanish exclave in North Africa this week had walked back to Morocco by Sunday, while others tried to blend in and stay on. Spanish civil guard ships continued searching for migrant bodies in the waters near the stretch of urban beach that tens of thousand of migrants had breached days earlier.

Shops in Ceuta reopened, and the usual blend of residents and tourists in the city of 84,000 were filling the open-air terraces, restaurants and cafes. But the city that prides itself on being home to four cultures was still grappling with the aftermath of the border surge, with locals disagreeing on what caused it and who exactly is to blame.

At least 72 migrants died, including some who drowned and others who were killed in



Migrants cross from Morocco into the Spanish enclave of Ceuta

AP/PTI

a stampede to cross a breakwater barrier, Spanish authorities said Sunday.

The humanitarian crisis caused by the sudden rush of people has reignited a debate around immigration in Europe and beyond. “It’s not the young men’s fault,” said Mohamad

Abdelkader Driss, 44, a waiter at a fried fish restaurant in town. “If you open the border, of course everyone comes in, but the young men aren’t to blame. The authorities are responsible.”

Some migrants who returned to Morocco described

a border that was effectively open and said authorities did little as they watched thousands of people cross.

The unauthorised arrivals on Thursday and Friday of 50,000 to 60,000, mostly young men, swelled Ceuta’s population by more than half.

Washington fires burned 600 structures, forced evacuation of 5,000 homes

The fires burned about 21 square kilometres around Spokane, the second largest city in Washington, and were among dozens across the western US

WASHINGTON: About 5,000 homes have been evacuated and about 600 homes, businesses and other buildings have been destroyed by wildfires that remained uncontained Sunday in eastern Washington state, authorities said.

The fires burned about 21 square kilometres around Spokane, the second largest city in Washington, and were among dozens across the western US — stretching the ability of federal, state and local agencies to fight them. No deaths have yet been reported from the fires in the Spokane area.

While the high temperature Sunday in Spokane was forecast to remain below 27 degrees Celsius, wind gusts from 56 kph to 72 kph were expected later in the day, said Benjamin Cossel, public information officer for the federal response team from California called in Saturday night to deal with the Spokane-area fires.

“We have weather working



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

against us, and we have terrain working against us,” Cossel said.

There were three fires in the Spokane area, the Old Trails Fire, the Fairview Fire and the Meadowview Fire, and the state issued air quality warnings. Washington Gov. Bob Ferguson declared a state of emergency Saturday, and the National Weather Service

issued a “particularly dangerous situation” red flag alert for eastern Washington.

Cossel said that as it gets warmer during the day, cool air that’s now closer to the ground and keeping winds at bay will rise, allowing those winds to move through the area. The Spokane River cuts through the city of about 229,000 people, and there are steep can-

yon on both sides that channel the wind.

“They push the fire through the canyons, up, up the slopes, and then outside the slopes and around,” he said. “It’s very, very hilly, very, very steep slopes, a lot of canyons that create really turbulent, really challenging sort of wind scenarios.”

Authorities in Spokane set up a shelter at the city’s main convention centre.

World Briefs

SECOND PHASE OF POLLING CONCLUDES IN POK AMID RIGGING ALLEGATIONS

LAHORE: The second phase of the so-called legislative elections in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir concluded on Sunday, marred by rigging allegations and violence. New Delhi maintains that the entire Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh, including the areas “currently under Pakistan’s illegal and forcible occupation, are integral and inalienable parts of India”. On July 28, India described the elections as an attempt by Pakistan to camouflage its illegal occupation and hide its “grave” human rights violations in the region. Early on Sunday, polling personnel were escorted to polling stations in “military-guarded convoys” with each vehicle accompanied by security personnel.

CURFEW RELAXED IN SOUTHERN NEPAL AS SITUATION IMPROVES AFTER CLASHES

KATHMANDU: Nepalese authorities on Sunday relaxed the curfew imposed in various parts of Madhesh and Koshi provinces as the security situation improved days after communal violence rocked the region. Three people have been killed in communal violence in Nepal that started after clashes erupted in Sunsari district bordering India in Koshi Province, prompting authorities to impose curfews, prohibitory orders and step up security deployment. The violence broke out after members of the two communities clashed over the use of loudspeakers.

US: 3 killed in Idaho restaurant shooting

BOISE: Three people were killed and seven more were injured, some critically, in a shooting at an In-N-Out Burger restaurant in southern Idaho on Saturday afternoon, a Twin Falls city spokesman said. Police who responded to the shooting found the body of the suspected gunman in an area near the restaurant, Twin Falls city public information officer Josh Palmer said. He did not know if the suspect was included in the fatality count.

Officials were still working on notifying the family members of victims and so were not yet releasing the names, ages or other details about the people hurt in the shooting, Palmer said.

Some of the people injured are in critical condition, Palmer said.

Police were still trying to determine the shooter’s identity and motive, Twin Falls Police Chief Matthew Hicks said in a news conference earlier Saturday. “We believe the threat to the community

Police who responded to the shooting found the body of the suspected gunman in an area near the restaurant

is over,” Hicks said. “It was a very chaotic scene.” Palmer said investigators were still interviewing witnesses to the shooting. The restaurant is in a busy shopping plaza, and hundreds of people were in the area when it happened around 2 pm.

Lane Koehn, 34, said he was at a stoplight near the In-N-Out when he saw a person with an AR-style rifle emerge from the drive-thru.

A man with a pistol started firing at the shooter. He then saw someone in an In-N-Out uniform drag a person, also uniformed, bleeding from a gunshot wound in her chest across the parking lot.

Fuel sales surge in July on weak rains, LPG demand shifts to PNG

Petrol sales by IOC, BPCL & HPCL climbed 9.7 % to 3.45 million tonnes during July, against 3.14 million tonnes during same period a year ago

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Petrol and diesel sales by India's three state-run fuel retailers rose sharply in July as below-normal monsoon rainfall boosted fuel demand from farmers and motorists, preliminary industry sales data showed.

Petrol sales by Indian Oil Corp (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corp Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corp Ltd (HPCL) climbed 9.7 per cent to 3.45 million tonnes during July, compared with 3.14 million tonnes in the corresponding period a year ago.

The volume was also 15.1 per cent higher than 2.99 million tonnes sold during July 2024 and 36.1 per cent above the level recorded in the same period of 2023.

Compared to June, however, petrol sales fell 1.1 per cent from 3.48 million tonnes.

Diesel sales, a key indicator of economic activity in India, rose 10.7 per cent year-on-year to 7.12 million tonnes in July from 6.43 million tonnes a year earlier.

Diesel is India's most widely used fuel, powering freight transport, agricultural machin-



The volume was also 15.1 per cent higher than 2.99 million tonnes sold during July 2024 and 36.1 per cent above the level recorded in the same period of 2023

ery and irrigation. Below-normal monsoon rainfall boosted irrigation demand during the peak sowing season.

The volume sold in July was 11.5 per cent higher than in the corresponding period of 2024 and 12.7 per cent above the July 2023 consumption. On a month-on-month basis, diesel

sales declined 9.2 per cent from 7.85 million tonnes in June.

Fuel sales typically moderate with the onset of the monsoon, which reduces demand for running agricultural irrigation pumps as well as slows vehicular movement. But this year, the monsoon rains arrived late, which led to farmers using

HIGHLIGHTS

» Compared to June, however, petrol sales fell 1.1 per cent from 3.48 million tonnes

» Diesel sales rose 10.7 per cent year-on-year to 7.12 million tonnes in July from 6.43 million tonnes a year earlier

» The volume sold in July was 11.5 per cent higher than in the corresponding period of 2024 and 12.7 per cent above the July 2023 consumption

» On month-on-month basis, diesel sales fell 9.2% from 7.85 million tonnes in June

diesel to run pumps to irrigate farms.

Month-on-month, sales in July remain lower because in June holiday travel picks up due to school and college holidays.

Jet fuel (ATF) sales inched up by 2.9 per cent to 659,900 tonnes during July -- volumes that were 2.3 per cent

more than the consumption of 641,300 tonnes in July 2024 and 16.5 per cent more than 566,600 tonnes of July 2023.

Month-on-month, the consumption fell 4.6 per cent from 691,700 tonnes of June.

Liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) sales continued to fall, dropping 17.4 per cent to 2.37 million tonnes.

Industry officials said this was largely because some volumes have shifted to piped natural gas (PNG) since the West Asia crisis.

LPG sales have been declining since the onset of the West Asia crisis disrupted supplies, leading to the imposition of consumption restrictions in sectors like hotels and restaurants.

The curbs were lifted last month, and sales saw an 8.6 per cent rise to 2.18 million tonnes consumed in June but were lower year-on-year as some industrial and commercial users are now using piped natural gas for their needs, they said.

The July LPG consumption was 13.3 per cent lower than 2.73 million tonnes of July 2024 and 1.1 per cent lower than 2.39 million tonnes of July 2023.

OPEC+ agrees Sept oil output hike of around 188,000 bpd

LONDON: OPEC+ approved an oil production quota increase on Sunday of around 188,000 barrels per day (bpd) from September, the producer group said, in a move that completes the unwinding of a layer of voluntary output cuts.

Due to export disruptions from the Gulf, Russia and Kazakhstan caused by the Iran and Ukraine wars, successive monthly OPEC+ hikes over most of this year have remained largely on paper with little impact on the market.

The September increase agreed by core OPEC+ members -- Saudi Arabia, Russia, Iraq, Kuwait, Algeria, Kazakhstan and Oman -- finishes the phased rollback of a 1.65 million bpd supply cut originally agreed in 2023, when the group still included the UAE, which left OPEC in May, *Reuters* reported.

Although OPEC+ sources said before the meeting the group would likely pause output increases for the fourth quarter, its statement made no reference to what might be agreed for the last three months of 2026.

A pause was still a feasible option, said Jorge Leon, an analyst at Rystad. "OPEC+ has finished unwinding its voluntary cuts. The next challenge is managing the surplus that could emerge as export flows normalise," he said.

"Having completed the restoration campaign, OPEC+ has little incentive to rush into further supply changes. Our base



OPEC+ is carrying out a review of its members' oil production capacity that will be used for 2027 output baselines from which quotas are set

case is a fourth-quarter pause while the group prepares for the 2027 quota negotiations."

Meanwhile, a separate OPEC+ meeting of a panel called the Joint Ministerial Monitoring Committee also met, OPEC said on Sunday, and reiterated concern about attacks on energy assets during the US-Israeli war on Iran, saying they were expensive and time-consuming to repair and so have an impact on supply.

With September's output hike now agreed, OPEC+ still

has in place one more layer of output cuts that apply to most of the group's members. Those roughly 2 million bpd in cuts date back to 2022 and are due to remain in place until the end of this year. OPEC+ is carrying out a review of its members' oil production capacity that will be used for the 2027 output baselines from which quotas are set.

It faces potentially difficult talks over new production quotas, with some members, including Iraq, pushing for higher individual quotas to reflect their higher capacity.

OPEC+ includes 21 members, comprising the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries along with Russia and other allies. In recent years only the seven core countries, and the UAE until its departure, have been involved in monthly production management.

The seven members will hold their next meeting on September 6. AGENCIES

India's power consumption up 11% to 170.7 BU in July



NEW DELHI: India's power consumption grew 10.93 per cent year-on-year to 170.70 billion units (BU) in July, official data showed, as high humidity levels pushed up use of cooling appliances like air conditioners in many parts of the country.

The country's total power consumption was 153.88 BU in July 2025.

The higher feel-like temperature than actual, caused by humid conditions across the country, increased use of cooling appliances like air conditioners, thereby increasing power demand and consumption, experts said.

The peak power demand also jumped to 270.20 GW last month from 220.74 GW in July 2025. The peak power demand in July hovered almost around the all-time record high of 270.82 GW seen in May.

The power demand in May last year was 230.99 GW. Last summer, the peak power demand was 242.77 GW, recorded in June 2025, but stayed below the government's estimate of 277 GW.

Experts said power demand will remain steady in August as well, with continued humid conditions in the ongoing monsoon.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has projected deficient rainfall in this year's monsoon. PTI

India's coal dispatch surges 17.3% in July as output growth stands at 7.5%

NEW DELHI: India's coal production rose 7.51 per cent year-on-year to 69.75 million tonnes (MT) in July 2026, while coal dispatch grew at a significantly faster pace of 17.34 per cent to 86.33 MT, according to provisional data released by the Ministry of Coal.

Coal production in July 2025 stood at 64.88 MT, while dispatch was 73.57 MT. The increase in both production and dispatch reflects the government's efforts to maintain coal availability and ensure operational stability across the sector.

Cumulatively, coal production during the first four months of FY27 reached 302.24 MT, according to the ministry. Coal dispatch during the same period stood at 354.70 MT, registering a 5.87 per cent year-on-year growth over the corresponding period of the previous financial year.

Coal India Ltd (CIL)



remained a key contributor to the sector's performance. The state-owned coal producer recorded production of 50.35 MT in July, representing an 8.42 per cent increase over July 2025.

CIL's coal dispatch also recorded strong growth during the month. The company dispatched 63.67 MT in July 2026, up 17.43 per cent year-on-year compared with the corresponding month last year.

The company's cumulative coal dispatch through July in FY27 also remained on an upward trajectory, recording 6.81 per cent growth compared with the same period a year ear-

lier. The stronger growth in coal dispatch compared with production indicates sustained movement of coal to consuming sectors during the month.

The Ministry of Coal said it remains focused on achieving sustainable growth in the coal sector, improving availability and reducing India's dependence on coal imports.

Coal continues to remain an important component of India's energy supply. The ministry said the positive momentum in production and dispatch would support the sector's role in powering the country's economic growth.

With cumulative production crossing 300 MT and dispatch exceeding 350 MT in the first four months of FY27, the ministry said the sector continues to demonstrate growth momentum while focusing on consistent supplies and operational stability. ANI

ZEEL seeks legal advice on Sebi order in land pledge case, says ₹2,300 cr fundraise on track

NEW DELHI: Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd (ZEEL) on Sunday said it is seeking legal advice on the Sebi's order barring the company from the securities market for two months and its Chairman Emeritus Subhash Chandra and Managing Director and CEO Punit Goenka for one year in the Hyderabad land pledge case.

The company said the regulator's order has no direct impact on its proposed Rs 2,300 crore fundraising exercise and indicated it may challenge the order before the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT).

A ZEEL spokesperson said the company has already secured approvals from stock

'The firm has already secured approvals from stock exchanges & shareholders for the capital raise at its July 31 EGM'

exchanges and shareholders for the capital raise at its Extraordinary General Meeting held on July 31, 2026.

"The company firmly believes that the order from Sebi has no direct bearing on the fundraising exercise," the spokesperson said, adding that ZEEL will take all necessary

steps to complete the fundraising, which is aimed at strengthening its financial position and creating long-term stakeholder value.

On Friday, Sebi barred ZEEL from accessing the securities market for two months and prohibited Chandra and Goenka from trading in the securities market for one year over the unauthorised pledge of the company's Hyderabad land to secure loans raised by promoter-linked Essel Group entities. The regulator also imposed a total penalty of Rs 1.48 crore, including Rs 30 lakh on ZEEL, Rs 60 lakh on Chandra and Rs 58 lakh on Goenka.

The case pertains to a December 2018 agreement

under which the title deeds of ZEEL's Hyderabad property were handed over to Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd as collateral for loans availed by Essel Home and other Essel Group-linked entities.

Sebi held that the transaction qualified as a related-party transaction and was executed without prior audit committee approval, violating Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements (LODR) regulations.

It also alleged that ZEEL failed to make necessary disclosures in its financial statements despite Chandra and Goenka being aware that the property remained pledged with the lender until June 2020. AGENCIES

NEW DELHI: The share of coal in India's power-generation mix dropped to its lowest in a year in July as renewable-power generation surged to a record high, government data showed.

Renewable power jumped to 20 per cent of India's mix, the data showed. It was 36.25 billion kilowatt-hours (kWh) in July, up 30 per cent from the same month last year.

Coal-power generation fell to 65.7 per cent in July from 69 per cent in June, according to *Reuters* calculations of daily data from the regulator, Grid-India.

The rise in India's clean-energy generation comes as solar and wind output exceeded

100 gigawatts for the first time and accounted for a record 42.8 per cent of India's electricity supply on July 13, government data showed.

Most of the peak power demand is happening during daytime where there is increased contribution from solar, said Manoj Kumar, an analyst with Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air, pointing to a rise in renewable share in the country's power generation.

Coal-fired power generation rose about 12.8 per cent year-on-year to 119.40 billion kWh in July, the data showed.

Analysts attributed the rise in coal-power generation to a fall in hydropower generation

and due to a strong El Nino pattern, where searing heat is driving demand for cooling during the nighttime.

Hydropower generation fell for a second straight month to 22.1 per cent on lower rainfall due to El Nino, which significantly shifts rainfall patterns and lifts above-normal temperatures.

Lower hydro generation due to El Nino and increased demand for power could lead to a power-generation gap of nearly 18 billion kWh and will drive a surge in coal-fired power in India, CREA said.

India's electricity generation in July rose 10.4 per cent from a year earlier to 181.79 billion kWh, the data showed. AGENCIES

India to fund ₹650 cr per well for 60 deepsea wells to break its oil import habit

Under the Samudra Manthan Scheme, govt will fund half of the drilling cost for deepsea, ultra-deep water exploration well or Rs 650 cr, whichever is lower

NEW DELHI: India is set to launch one of the world's first large-scale government-funded offshore oil and gas exploration programmes, aiming to reduce its dependence on imported crude and natural gas by backing high-risk deepwater exploration.

The Union Cabinet has approved the Rs 84,084-crore Samudra Manthan National Offshore Exploration Scheme, under which the Centre will fund up to 50 per cent of the cost of drilling a deepwater or ultra-deepwater exploration well, subject to a ceiling of Rs 650 crore per well. Officials said

60 such wells will receive support over the next five years.

The scheme also provides funding for common infrastructure such as subsea pipelines and onshore processing facilities, enabling multiple operators to commercialise discoveries using shared assets. Officials said companies have traditionally focused on development drilling because unsuccessful exploration requires them to write off investments.

The incentive will be available to companies holding exploration blocks under earlier and ongoing Open Acreage Licensing Programme (OALP)



rounds. Officials expect the initiative to attract global energy firms and accelerate exploration activity.

ICRA Senior Vice President Prashant Vashisht said the scheme addresses key bot-

CLOSER LOOK

- » The scheme also provides funding for common infra such as subsea pipelines and onshore processing facilities
- » Of the total outlay, Rs 43,200 crore has been earmarked for deepwater and ultra-deepwater drilling support through 2031
- » Another Rs 10,000 crore will fund common infrastructure such as pipelines and processing facilities

tlenecks by funding offshore seismic surveys and supporting capital-intensive deepwater drilling, where India has limited expertise. He said the programme could add 10-15 million tonnes of oil equivalent

annually, reducing import dependence by 3-5 per cent.

Of the total outlay, Rs 43,200 crore has been earmarked for deepwater and ultra-deepwater drilling support through 2031. Another Rs

10,000 crore will fund common infrastructure such as pipelines and processing facilities.

The government has allocated Rs 28,534 crore for offshore seismic and geological surveys to identify promising reserves, while Rs 2,000 crore will support oil and gas manufacturing and services hubs.

A key feature of the scheme is the Common Hub Infrastructure (CHI) model, which allows multiple operators to share offshore infrastructure instead of developing separate facilities.

Officials said the model will lower project costs, improve

resource utilisation, simplify offshore logistics and speed up commercialisation of smaller discoveries, particularly in deepwater and ultra-deepwater areas.

India's crude oil import dependence has risen from about 77 per cent to 88 per cent over the past decade, while nearly half of its natural gas requirement is also imported.

Officials said recent geopolitical disruptions in West Asia underscored the need to strengthen domestic production and reduce exposure to global supply shocks.

The government expects the scheme to unlock offshore hydrocarbon reserves by encouraging exploration and attracting global technology and investment.

The initiative builds on reforms introduced under the Hydrocarbon Exploration and Licensing Policy (HELP), the Open Acreage Licensing Programme (OALP) and the Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Amendment Act, 2025, which simplified licensing, introduced graded royalties and provided greater policy stability for exploration. AGENCIES

Higher tobacco tax hits cigarette makers’ Q1 net profit & revenue

ITC, Godfrey Phillips & VST Industries together account for over 90% of domestic cigarette market, annual volume of over 100–120 bn sticks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government’s steep increase in taxes on cigarettes and tobacco products has started weighing on the country’s leading cigarette makers, with ITC, Godfrey Phillips India, and VST Industries reporting declines in net revenue, volumes and profitability in the April-June quarter, the first full quarter after the revised tax regime came into effect.

The three companies together account for more than 90 per cent of the domestic cigarette market, which, according to some reports, has an estimated annual volume of over 100–120 billion sticks.

Earlier in February this year, the government raised the goods and services tax (GST) on cigarettes and tobacco products to a flat 40 per cent. It replaced the compensation cess with a new additional excise duty ranging from Rs 2,100–8,500 per 1,000 sticks, depending on cigarette length.

Though reported revenues from operations of cigarette companies surged as the higher duty component was reflected in sales, their underlying revenues (net revenue) and profits came under pressure as compa-



Earlier in February this year, the govt raised the GST on cigarettes and tobacco products to a flat 40%

nies grappled with the impact of the unprecedented tax increase.

In Q1 FY27, market leader ITC’s revenue from the cigarettes business grew 73.71 per cent to Rs 16,596.67 crore, from Rs 9,553.86 crore a year earlier — a rise which the company attributed to its “staggered pricing approach amidst unprecedented increase in tax”.

However, the company’s gross revenue (from sale of products and services) in the cigarettes segment, which strips out duty pass-through, actually fell 31.45 per cent to Rs 3,769.11 crore, from Rs 5,498.93 crore in

HIGHLIGHTS

» ITC’s gross revenue in cigarettes segment, fell 31.45% to Rs 3,769.11 crore, from Rs 5,498.93 crore in Q1 FY26

» Godfrey Phillips India reported a 44.3% decline in consolidated net profit to Rs 198.39 crore for Q1 FY27

» VST Industries’ PAT fell 24.42 per cent to Rs 42.42 crore, from Rs 56.13 crore in Q1 FY26

Q1 FY26 — pointing to a hit on underlying sales volumes.

ITC, which controls over three-fourths of the domestic cigarette market, said it had mounted a “strategic & calibrated response by the Cigarettes Business to the unprecedented increase in tax, balancing the interests of all stakeholders”. ITC’s cigarette brands include India Kings, Insignia and Classic in the premium segment, and Gold Flake, Wills Navy Cut, Scissors, Capstan and Players in the mass-market segment.

Godfrey Phillips India

reported a 44.3 per cent decline in consolidated net profit to Rs 198.39 crore for Q1 FY27.

Revenue from operations of the Modi Enterprises firm nearly doubled to Rs 3,819.56 crore, largely on account of Rs 2,614 crore in excise duty paid during the quarter. Excluding excise, its net revenue fell 18.8 per cent to Rs 1,206 crore, from Rs 1,486 crore in the year-ago period, the company said.

Godfrey Phillips sells cigarettes under brands, including Cavanders, Four Square, Red & White, Stellar, North Pole and Tipper, besides Marlboro, which is owned by Philip Morris.

VST Industries, which owns the Total, Editions and Charms brands, said its quarterly performance was also weighed down by the sharp tax increase.

Its revenue nearly doubled to Rs 881.49 crore in Q1 FY27, from Rs 424.93 crore a year earlier, but PAT fell 24.42 per cent to Rs 42.42 crore, from Rs 56.13 crore in Q1 FY26. The company’s net revenue declined 13.5 per cent to Rs 256 crore, comprising Rs 216 crore from the cigarette business and Rs 40 crore from unmanufactured tobacco, against Rs 296 crore (Rs 255 crore and Rs 41 crore, respectively) in the correspond-

ing quarter of FY26.

VST Industries’ Cigarette Volume (average per month in million) was down 14 per cent to 611 from 714 of the corresponding period a year ago.

The government had, with effect from February 1, revamped the taxation structure for tobacco products by imposing an additional excise duty on cigarettes and other tobacco products and a health cess on pan masala, over and above the highest GST slab of 40 per cent.

It had replaced the earlier tax regime of 28 per cent GST plus compensation cess that had been applicable since the rollout of the GST system in July 2017. Under the revised structure, short non-filter cigarettes of up to 65 mm attract an additional duty of about Rs 2.05 per stick, while short filter cigarettes of the same length are subject to an additional duty of around Rs 2.10 per stick.

Following the implementation of the new duty structure, cigarette prices were immediately jumped by about Rs 22–25 per pack of 10 sticks across several categories, prompting manufacturers to undertake calibrated price hikes and portfolio adjustments at that time.

‘RBI likely to maintain neutral stance, as inflation risks persist’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is expected to keep the benchmark repo rate unchanged in its August monetary policy review on elevated inflation risks and pending the closure of the FCNR(B) deposit scheme, a poll of 10 economists and treasury heads has revealed.

Most respondents anticipate that the central bank will maintain its policy stance as ‘Neutral’ while adopting a hawkish tone amid rising inflation risks from geopolitical tensions, elevated crude oil prices and an uneven monsoon.

Economists said the central bank will remain in a “wait-and-watch” mode as it assesses the evolving inflation outlook.

“As of now, trimmed core inflation remains benign and suggests a status quo is the best policy option for the time being, with caution being expressed through the policy tone,” said Aditi Nayar, chief economist at ICRA.

In recent media outings, Governor Sanjay Malhotra has reiterated that inflation will be the central bank’s foremost priority going ahead

since last year to aid growth. Despite expectations of a pause in August, the majority of respondents see the policy rate moving higher over the course of FY27. Most participants expect at least two rate hikes during the fiscal year if inflationary pressures intensify. “The RBI is expected to maintain a hawkish pause, balancing resilient domestic growth with supply-led inflation. Since inflation is largely driven by external shocks rather than demand, keeping rates unchanged allows the RBI to assess evolving risks like monsoon developments and geopolitical disruptions before taking further action,” said Balasubramanian R, head of treasury at Dhanlaxmi Bank. Most respondents expect no change in the central bank’s inflation forecast



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Foreign investors turn net buyers after 4 straight months of selling, invest ₹20,200 crore in July

NEW DELHI: After four straight months of selling, foreign investors turned net buyers of Indian equities in July, pumping in Rs 20,200 crore, aided by attractive valuations, improving corporate earnings and easing global headwinds.

The latest inflow marks a sharp reversal from the preceding months, when Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) withdrew Rs 49,340 crore in June, Rs 32,963 crore in May, Rs 60,847 crore in April and a massive Rs 1.17 lakh crore in March, according to data from the Central Depository Services (India) Ltd (CDSL).

Prior to the four-month selling spree, FPIs had invested Rs 22,615 crore in Indian equities in February.

Despite the turnaround

Prior to four-month selling spree, FPIs had invested Rs 22,615 cr in Indian equities in February

in July, foreign investors have pulled out a net Rs 2.54 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026, way more than the Rs 1.66 lakh crore withdrawn during the whole of 2025.

Market experts attributed the renewed foreign investor interest to relatively stable domestic markets, reasonable large-cap valuations, improving earnings prospects and a more favourable global environment.

V K Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit

Investments, said excessive volatility in markets such as South Korea and Taiwan, coupled with concentration risk in the “chip trade”, is prompting FPIs to look for relatively stable markets like India.

The stability of the rupee and fair valuations of India’s large-cap stocks are other factors facilitating renewed FPI inflows into the country, he added.

Vedant Gupte, Co-Founder and CEO of investment platform Trackk, said improving earnings prospects also strengthened investor sentiment, with June quarter results showing signs of recovery across key sectors. IT stocks, in particular, witnessed a sharp re-rating as better-than-expected earnings helped ease concerns over

the impact of artificial intelligence on the sector’s growth prospects, he said.

At the same time, easing pressure from the US dollar and expectations that US interest rates are near their peak have improved the investment environment for emerging markets, Gupte added.

Foreign investor interest was not limited to equities, with the debt market continuing to attract significant inflows during the month.

FPIs invested Rs 29,212 crore in debt through the general route and another Rs 3,033 crore through the fully accessible route in July. Going forward, the trajectory of foreign flows is likely to be influenced by both global developments and domestic triggers. PII

Mcap of nine of top-10 most valued companies jumps ₹2.51 lakh crore

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of nine of the top-10 most-valued firms jumped Rs 2.51 lakh crore last week, with Bajaj Finance emerging as the biggest winner, in tandem with a positive trend in equities.

While Reliance Industries, Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) were the gainers from the top-10 pack, Hindustan Unilever emerged as the only laggard.

The market valuation of Bajaj Finance surged Rs 80,345.97 crore to Rs 7,10,817.51 crore, the most among the top-10 firms. Shares of NBFC Bajaj Finance on Friday ended over 8 per cent higher after the firm



reported a 28 per cent year-on-year rise in consolidated profit after tax (PAT) for the June quarter of FY27.

Bharti Airtel’s valuation soared Rs 44,959.5 crore to reach Rs 12,30,005.63 crore.

The market valuation of TCS jumped Rs 40,414.03 crore to Rs 8,55,894.78 crore and that of Reliance Industries climbed Rs 39,447.35 crore to Rs 17,69,108.79 crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of Larsen & Toubro

rallied Rs 21,096.8 crore to Rs 5,41,844.69 crore and that of State Bank of India edged higher by Rs 10,845.97 crore to Rs 9,47,799.81 crore.

HDFC Bank’s mcap advanced Rs 8,164.73 crore to Rs 11,52,150.63 crore.

The valuation of LIC went up Rs 4,427.49 crore to Rs 5,37,435.05 crore and that of ICICI Bank climbed Rs 1,660.37 crore to Rs 10,29,878.30 crore.

However, the mcap of Hindustan Unilever declined Rs 10,326.46 crore to Rs 4,93,602.13 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most valued firm, followed by Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, LIC, and Hindustan Unilever. PII

Gold & silver likely to trade in narrow range this week

NEW DELHI: Gold and silver are likely to trade in a narrow range this week as traders await a raft of economic data, including the US non-farm payrolls report, for fresh clues on the Federal Reserve’s interest rate outlook, analysts said.

Investors will monitor PMI data from the US, the UK, the EU & Japan. Focus will remain on July employment data from the US, comprising non-farm payrolls & unemployment rate.

Globally, developments surrounding the US-Iran conflict & stability of crude oil supplies through key shipping routes will remain important drivers of market sentiment, they added.

On the domestic front, gold futures for August delivery fell by Rs 1,595, or 1.1 per cent, during the last week to close at Rs 1.41 lakh per 10 grams.

Silver futures for the September contract declined Rs 4,940, or 2.2 per cent, to settle at Rs 2.17 lakh per kilogram on the MCX.

In the international markets, Comex gold futures for October delivery ended marginally lower at \$4,076.6/ounce, while silver for the September contract during the past week slipped nearly 2 per cent to finish at \$57.78/ounce in New York. PII

Maruti Suzuki India clocks record production of 2,48,845 units in July

NEW DELHI: Maruti Suzuki India (MSI) reported its highest-ever monthly production in July, rolling out 2,48,845 vehicles, up 33 per cent from 1,87,073 units in the same month last year.

The July output surpassed the company’s previous production record of 2,31,933 units achieved in March 2026, according to a regulatory filing.

Despite the record production, MSI Senior Executive Officer (Marketing & Sales) Partho Banerjee said dealer inventory remained significantly below the industry average. The com-



pany retailed 1.78 lakh vehicles in July, leaving dealer stock at just 16 days against the industry norm of around 30 days. Pending customer bookings stood at about 1.6 lakh units.

The company also posted its highest-ever domestic passenger vehicle wholesales at

1,96,203 units in July, up 43 per cent from 1,37,776 units a year earlier. Total domestic sales, including light commercial vehicles, reached a record 2,00,123 units.

Production of compact cars, including Baleno, Celerio and Swift, rose to 1,13,067 units from 87,950 units a year ago. Utility vehicle output, comprising Brezza, Ertiga and Fronx, climbed 46 per cent to 1,02,787 units. Production of Eco vans increased to 14,627 units, while Super Carry light commercial vehicle output rose to 4,400 units. AGENCIES

NEW DELHI: The domestic stock market is entering a significant trading week, with the Reserve Bank of India’s interest rate decision, West Asia situation involving the US-Iran conflict, and crude oil prices emerging as the major driving factors for investors’ sentiment, analysts said.

Besides, quarterly earnings and trading activity of foreign investors would also be tracked by investors to determine further movement, they added.

“This week is expected to be eventful, with the RBI Monetary Policy Committee (MPC)



meeting (August 3–5) emerging as the key domestic trigger. Market participants will also closely monitor the ongoing Q1 FY27 earnings season, with several largecap and mid-cap companies scheduled to announce their results,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Reli-

gare Broking Ltd, said.

Globally, developments surrounding the US-Iran conflict, stability of crude oil supplies through key shipping routes will remain important drivers of market sentiment, he added.

After four straight months of selling, foreign investors turned net buyers of Indian equities in July, pumping in Rs 20,200 crore, aided by attractive valuations, improving corporate earnings and easing global headwinds.

Investor attention this week will remain firmly focused on geopolitical developments in

West Asia, with any further escalation in the US-Iran conflict likely to have an immediate impact on crude oil prices and broader global risk sentiment, Ponmudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Among major quarterly earnings this week are from earning DLF, Bharti Airtel, ONGC, Hero MotoCorp, LIC, and State Bank of India.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex climbed 2,034.87 points, or 2.67 per cent, and the NSE Nifty surged 616.15 points, or 2.59 per cent. PII

Achyuta Samanta conferred 75th Honorary Doctorate by Maharaja Ganga Singh University

The honorary degree was presented to him at a special convocation ceremony organised by the university at Raj Bhavan (Lok Bhavan) in Jaipur on Friday

BHUBANESWAR: Eminent educationist, social reformer, and Founder of KIIT and KISS, Dr. Achyuta Samanta, has been conferred an Honorary Doctorate by Maharaja Ganga Singh University (MGSU), Bikaner, one of Rajasthan’s oldest government universities.

The honorary degree was presented to Dr. Samanta at a special convocation ceremony organised by the university at the Raj Bhavan (Lok Bhavan) in Jaipur on Friday.

The university recognised his extraordinary contribution to the advancement of society and human welfare through education by bestowing upon him this prestigious honour.

This is the 75th Honorary Doctorate conferred on Dr. Samanta, further strengthen-

ing his standing as one of the most widely honoured educationists and social reformers from India.

The university selected him for the honour after making a comprehensive assessment of his life, achievements and contributions.

The honorary doctorate was presented by Haribhau Bagde, Governor of Rajasthan and Chancellor of Maharaja Ganga Singh University. The ceremony was attended by Prem Chand Bairwa, Deputy Chief Minister of Rajasthan and Minister for Higher Education; Prof. Manoj Dixit, Vice-Chancellor of MGSU; Prof. Yashpal Ahuja, Registrar of the university; along with several ministers, legislators and other distinguished

personalities from the state. On the same occasion, Vijaya Kishore Rahatkar, Chairperson of the National Commission for Women, was also conferred an Honorary Doctorate.

The latest recognition comes amid a series of prestigious national and international honours received by Dr. Samanta in recent years. Earlier this year, he was presented the AAPI Award for Transformational Social Work & Indo-US Partnership by the American Association of Physicians of Indian Origin (AAPIO) at its annual convention in Tampa, Florida, in recognition of his contributions to social transformation and strengthening Indo-US collaboration.

He was also conferred the Grand Cross Award, the high-



The university recognised his extraordinary contribution to the advancement of society and human welfare through education by bestowing upon him this prestigious honour

est honour of the International Volleyball Federation (FIVB), during the 39th FIVB World

Congress in Porto, Portugal, for his exceptional contribution to the promotion and develop-

ment of volleyball.

In another global recognition, the World Academy of Art and Culture (WAAC) honoured him with its Lifetime Achievement Award for his transformative contributions to society at the 43rd World Congress of Poets held in Madurai.

Dr. Samanta’s work has also received recognition in the academic world. The City University of New York (CUNY) established the Achyuta Samanta India Initiative CUNY Crest Institute (ASIIICI) in his honour, acknowledging his pioneering work in education, social inclusion and community development.

Over the years, he has also received several distinguished international rec-

ognitions, including the ISA Award for Service to Humanity, the highest civilian award of the Kingdom of Bahrain, the Gusi Peace Prize International from Manila, often referred to as Asia’s Peace Prize, and the Golden Gavel from the World Academy of Arts and Culture, recognised by UNESCO.

He has also been conferred the highest civilian honours of Mongolia and Bahrain, besides receiving four national and international fellowships and more than 50 national and international honours along with over 200 state-level awards.

The award by the university in Rajasthan further strengthens Dr Samanta’s reputation in the academic firmament. Maharaja Ganga Singh Uni-

versity is widely recognised as one of Rajasthan’s leading government universities.

Expressing his gratitude, Dr. Samanta thanked Governor Haribhau Bagde and the university authorities for organising a special convocation at the Raj Bhavan to honour him, bringing him all the way from Odisha.

He also appreciated the recognition and appreciation shown towards Odisha and the work being carried out by him.

Dr. Samanta said that the honour would remain a cherished memory throughout his life. As August 2 marks the 10th death anniversary of his late mother, Nilimarani, he dedicated the honour to her and prayed for the eternal peace of her soul. MPOST

WINS MAIDEN BWF SUPER 300 TITLE

India's Tanvi Sharma becomes youngest Taipei Open champion

TAIPEI CITY: Teen Indian sensation Tanvi Sharma clinched her maiden BWF World Tour title after defeating Vietnam's sixth seed Thuy Linh Nguyen in straight games in the women's singles final of the Taipei Open Super 300 badminton tournament here on Sunday.

The 17-year-old from Punjab, who had finished runner-up at last year's US Open Super 300, needed just 36 minutes to outclass world No. 21 Nguyen 21-16 21-16 in the summit clash.

"I'm really very happy to win this title here," said Tanvi, who became the youngest champion in Taipei Open history at just 17 years and 222 days old, surpassing the legendary Tai Tzu Ying.

"I didn't expect to win a title, but yeah, I just thought I'll give my best over here. So I was going step by step, match by match. So yeah, every match I played really well here."

Coached by PV Sindhu's former mentor Park Tae-sang, Tanvi also became the first Indian to win the women's singles title at the Taipei Open since Saina Nehwal, who had lifted the trophy in 2008.

"I was quite nervous, but



Teen Indian sensation Tanvi Sharma

I just thought I will play my 100 percent, what I have in my game, I will play that," said Tanvi, who dropped only one game all week.

"It was pretty hard for me as well, playing five matches. But yeah, I just needed to be consistent. I have to work harder for playing Super 500 and 750s. So I'll be keep working hard."

Tanvi had defeated Nguyen en route to the final at US Open. The Indian made a flying start, repeatedly catching Nguyen at the front court with

deft drops played with the same action as a smash to open up a 4-1 lead.

The Vietnamese struggled to read the Indian's deception and also found it difficult to judge the drift, going wide twice as Tanvi mixed steep cross-court smashes with her trademark touch to surge to a 10-2 advantage. The Indian, however, suddenly slipped into a string of errors, struggling to keep the shuttle inside the lines. She eventually produced a timely smash to carry a three-

Highlights

- » She defeated Vietnam's sixth seed Thuy Linh Nguyen in straight games
- » The 17-year-old from Punjab needed just 36 minutes to outclass world No. 21
- » Tanvi found her rhythm after the break, producing powerful smashes from both flanks to move 15-9 ahead

point lead into the mid-game interval, with coach Park Tae-sang urging her to relax.

Tanvi found her rhythm after the break, producing powerful smashes from both flanks to move 15-9 ahead. Though she gifted away a few points with errors at the net and from the back court, she regained control, earning five game points before sealing the opening game with a cross-court smash.

After the change of ends, Nguyen opened a 3-0 lead by

making Tanvi cover the court with sharp angles.

But the Indian slowly began dictating the rallies, drawing level at 3-3 with a fine net shot before once again pushing her opponent deep and catching her at the net with deft touches.

Nguyen's inconsistency also helped Tanvi build an 8-4 lead before another patch of errors allowed the Vietnamese to close the gap to 7-8, prompting Park to tap his head in frustration. Two exquisite deceptive winners helped Tanvi take an 11-8 lead at the interval.

The Indian gradually stretched the advantage to 15-10 and then 18-12, her deception once again fetching crucial points. At 19-12, Tanvi unsuccessfully challenged a line call after being ruled late, but soon earned seven match points with a smash. A nervous finish saw her squander three of them before she finally converted to seal her maiden BWF title.

In a heartwarming moment, Tanvi took off her gold medal and placed it around coach Park Tae-sang's neck before the two posed together for photographs.

Bumrah ruled out of SL series, Auqib Nabi set to be drafted in

Nabi all set to earn his maiden call-up to national team

NEW DELHI: Premier pacer Jasprit Bumrah is set to miss India's two-Test tour of Sri Lanka as he is yet to recover from his knee injury.

Jammu and Kashmir seamer Auqib Nabi is all set to earn his maiden call-up to the national team.

Nabi will be the third player after Parvez Rasool and Umran Malik to get a senior national call-up. Rasool and Malik were summoned in white ball set-up.

"Bumrah is not fit and Auqib Nabi has been approved as his replacement," a BCCI source informed PTI. Nabi has picked 100-plus wickets in the last two Ranji Trophy seasons and was the chief architect of J&K's red-ball triumph. He is also a handy customer with the bat.

The swelling in Bumrah's knee seems to be more serious than it initially looked and the Sports Science team at Bengaluru's Centre of Excellence doesn't want to rush the seasoned pacer to the grind of international cricket, keeping in mind a packed calendar ahead.

"The two people who run the COE, Dhyananjay and Thulasi have decided that Bumrah can't be risked. It must be said that initially both team management and selection commit-



India's player Jasprit Bumrah in action

Key Points

- » Sri Lanka series begins on August 15 in Galle
- » Nabi has picked 100-plus wickets in the last two Ranji Trophy seasons
- » The swelling in Bumrah's knee seems to be more serious than it initially looked

tee were made to believe that Bumrah could be available for at least one of the two Tests," a BCCI source informed, citing how COE's functioning have left everyone baffled.

The Sri Lanka series begins

on August 15 in Galle.

The 32-year-old had missed out on the third ODI against England at the Lord's last month after sustaining an impact injury. He recently reported at the Centre Of Excellence in Bengaluru and was expected to be match-fit by the time Sri Lanka series begins. However, it has been learnt that Bumrah is still feeling some discomfort.

Even if he gets fit before August 15 or the second Test starting at Colombo on August 23, the medical team isn't sure if a Test match is the correct format to bring him back due to the massive workload on the docile tracks.

Asian Games medal next target amid pressure of expectations: Mirabai

NEW DELHI: Olympic silver medallist and three-time consecutive CWG gold medallist Mirabai Chanu acknowledged the pressure of high expectations, saying her next target is an elusive Asian Games medal.

Chanu began her ascent at the 2014 Glasgow CWG with a silver medal before winning three consecutive golds in her weight category in Gold Coast in 2018, Birmingham in 2022 and Glasgow again in 2026. She also won the World Championships gold in 2017 and silver medals in 2022 and 2025, besides medals at the Asian and Commonwealth Championships.

"Winning a medal makes you very happy, but it is also very difficult. You have more responsibilities and have to give your best in upcoming



Olympic silver medallist and three-time consecutive CWG gold medallist Mirabai Chanu

competitions.

"There is a lot of pressure. An Asian Games medal will be very important for me."

"I will try my best because I have to win where I have never won a medal before. So, the Asian Games is very important for me. Yes, I am aiming for an Asian Games medal next, for which there is pressure," Chanu told PTI in an interview here

on Sunday after returning from her successful CWG campaign in Glasgow.

"Some athletes are very happy when they win a medal. But for me, winning a medal gives me strength. I think I have to work even harder to win the next medal," she added.

Recalling her happiest and saddest career moments -- both at different Olympics -- Chanu said regrouping and competing at her best again was difficult.

"There is a lot of pressure in every competition that I have to win this medal. That has been the story. Every athlete wants to participate in the Olympics. Getting a medal there was a dream, but I felt very sad when I missed it by a whisker in the Paris Olympics.

Judoka Ishroop loses bronze medal bout

GLASGOW: Judoka Ishroop Narang gave her all in the bronze medal play-off but lost to Canadian Coralie Godbout by yuko as India's judo campaign ended at the Commonwealth Games without any medal on the concluding day of the quadrennial event here Sunday.

The hopes to add one more medal in the Indian tally were riding on Ishroop after she jumped into medal contention following her tremendous win over Cameroon's stronger and taller Georgika Wesley Djengue Moune in the repechage round of women's -78 kg.

The 19-year-old won by waza-ari after her opponent scored two yukos.

Ankur, Yashaswini bag men's, women's title in Commonwealth TT championships

NEW DELHI: Ankur Bhattacharjee and Yashaswini Ghorpade clinched the men's and women's singles title with contrasting wins at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships here on Sunday.

Bhattacharjee emerged a deserving 4-3 winner over Payas Jain after a hard-fought match.

Payas looked set for victory after opening a 7-4 lead in the deciding game.

However, Ankur called a timeout that disrupted his opponent's rhythm, and fought back to level at 8-8. He then edged ahead 10-9, and eventually sealed the title 11-9 when Payas' return drifted long.



Yashaswini Ghorpade

FILE PHOTO

In the women's final, Ghorpade delivered a commanding performance to defeat Sreeja Akula 4-1.

India dominated the championships, winning all but one of the gold medals on offer.

ting Sreeja under immense pressure.

Sreeja responded admirably, taking the third game 11-8 to keep her hopes alive, but Ghorpade quickly regained control, claiming the fourth game 11-7 and moving within touching distance of the title.

The fifth game produced the most entertaining contest of the match, with both players matching each other point-for-point in a tense finish.

Although Sreeja fought hard and saved two championship points, she failed to benefit from crucial opportunities at the business end. Yashaswini held her nerve to convert her third match point, sealing a 13-11 victory and the championship in style.

Medallists receive heroes' welcome on return



Gold medallist Mirabai Chanu being welcomed on her arrival at Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi on Sunday

NEW DELHI: The first batch of Indian athletes, including ace weightlifter Mirabai Chanu and Lovepreet Singh, returned home to a heroes' welcome after a successful Commonwealth Games campaign with hundreds of fans lining up to receive them at the Indira Gandhi International Airport here on Sunday. Olympic medallist Mirabai clinched her third successive Commonwealth Games gold medal in the women's 49kg event. "Coming from Manipur, I feel really proud that I have done something good for my country," Mirabai told PTI at the airport.

Lovepreet, who settled for silver in the men's +110kg category after narrowly missing the gold by just one kilogram, said his next target is the Asian Games in Japan.

"I would like to thank my Indian Navy staff and captain Vijay Kumar, and all who have come," said the 28-year-old from Punjab, who lifted a total of 388kg, including a Commonwealth Games record of 176kg in the snatch.

"It happens (missing on gold), but I did my hard work and I have got the result for that and when two players fight one

has to lose. Up next, I will prepare well for Asian Games."

Happy with the warm welcome on their return, Bindyarani Devi Sorokhaibam, who claimed bronze in the women's 58kg category, said she would work even harder ahead of the upcoming competitions.

"Everyone has welcomed us like this so it feels great, thank-you all for making feel like home," she said. "I'll train even harder than I have so far for the upcoming competitions."

Rishikanta Singh, who won silver in the men's 60kg category, said he would strive for gold the next time. "Feeling good that I have got a medal for India. I've already spoken about my performance, but I'll come back stronger and perform even better," Rishikanta said.

The Imphal-born Indian Army weightlifter also appealed for peace in his home state, saying it would help produce more sporting talent.

"For me both Navy and Meitei are equal. I would want to say this that we need peace in Manipur so that Manipur could produce more athletes even better than me," he said.

CHANDIGARH: India stars Shubman Gill, Arshdeep Singh, Abhishek Sharma, Gurnoor Brar, Prabhsimran Singh and Ramandeep Singh are some of the big names who are set to feature in the upcoming Sher-e-Punjab T20 League, which was unveiled here on Sunday.

The official logo of the tournament — to be played between August 30 and September 13 — was launched at the Punjab Cricket Association International Cricket Stadium at Mullanpur. However, Gill, India's Test and ODI skipper, and pacer Brar will be on national duty in Sri Lanka until August 28.

Gill said the event is going to provide a great opportunity for all the young players who want to play for Punjab or represent India.

"It is going to be a great platform for all of them," said Gill during the function which was attended by PCA president Amarjeet Mehta, Secretary Gurmeet Singh. A total

Lisha Das finishes 6th

GLASGOW: Teenage paracyclist Lisha Das finished sixth and last in the women's C4-C5 1000m time trial final, ending her impressive run and marking the conclusion of India's campaign at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games here on Sunday.

Das ended in sixth position, clocking a time of 1:34.410.



Punjab Cricket Association (PCA) Chairman Meet Hayer, second right, cricketers Shubman Gill, right, and Arshdeep Singh, left, and others during the logo launch of 'Sher-e-Punjab T20 League', at the PCA Stadium, in New Chandigarh on Sunday

of six teams will compete in 27 matches for the coveted title. The tournament will be played in a round-robin format, and each franchise will have one marquee player and at least two icon players.

Gill also recalled his early days of playing cricket in Fazilka, a village in Punjab,

and how father backed him to pursue his dreams.

"We also run a cricket academy in our village where free coaching is given so that children from the nearby areas can come and play there."

"Whenever my father gets some free time, he goes to the academy to watch the children



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Dgipr/2026-27/2038
Goraksha Gadilkar, L.A.S
Chief Executive Officer,

Proud BFI hopeful of similar show at Asian Games

NEW DELHI: Boxing Federation of India president Ajay Singh on Sunday lauded the Indian pugilists for their remarkable 10-medal show at the Commonwealth Games and urged them to work even harder to repeat the exceptional performance at the Asian Games in Japan next month.

Indian boxers returned with a record haul of 10 medals from the CWG, including seven gold and three silver, a first in the history of the Games for the country. "We had an exceptional and historic last two days. Winning seven gold and three silver in boxing is the biggest performance in the last 100 years history of Commonwealth Games," Singh said during an online interaction from Glasgow.

"This is also a preparation for future events, the Asian Games and 2028 Olympics. We can replicate

such a performance in Asian Games, we are top 3 in Asia in boxing but for that we need to prepare hard from now and be focussed to produce a strong performance." The BFI chief said those boxers who have won medals at the CWG have automatically booked their Asian Games berths. "We had already announced that boxers who are going for CWG and enter medal rounds will automatically be selected for Asian Games," Singh said.

"We are very hungry for a historic performance in Asian Games. But we need to become stronger, better in many weight categories. A lot of work has to be done, this was just a stepping stone."

"We are an athlete-centric federation and our programme is ready till 2028. We want to restart league format or professional format domestically this year to give more exposure to boxers."

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ajeet Sharma, S/o Lt. Ranvir, R/o B-181, Jaswant Colony, Budh Vihar Phase-2, Rohini, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 991/2017, U/s 324 IPC, P.S. Vijay Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Ajeet Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Ajeet Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ajeet Sharma** accused of **FIR No. 991/2017, U/s 324 IPC, P.S. Vijay Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026**.

By Order - **Ms. Shagun**
Judicial Magistrate First Class
DP/10678/RD/2026 Room No. 109, Rohini Courts, Delhi



my

'I'M HERE TO FIND my own audience'

Mahima Makwana's 'Musafir Café' is another step in a career that she is determined to shape on her own terms

Mumbai: Mahima Makwana believes every actor eventually has to find their own audience and her latest 'Netflix' series 'Musafir Café' is another step in a career that she is determined to shape on her own terms.

The unpredictability of the showbiz world has taught her patience and perseverance, said the actress, who started as a child actor on daily soaps 'Miley Jab Hum Tum' and 'Balika Vadhu' before making the transition to films with Salman Khan's 'Antim: The Final Truth' and later to OTT projects such as 'Tumse Na Hoo Payega' and 'Showtime'.

"I feel that if I can do it, everybody can do it. It's important to dream; it's all about believing in yourself. I'll always be grateful to the people who saw that potential in me. At the same time, our industry demands patience and perseverance. It's not an easy industry and there is hardly anything in your control. All you can control are the choices you make from the offers you're given. You learn, you unlearn, you realise and you create your own niche. I'm here to find my own audience, to create my own path and that's how I've been navigating my journey,"



She said the unpredictability of the showbiz world has taught her patience and perseverance

Makwana told PTI in an interview. Makwana credits 'Antim', which featured her alongside Salman and Ayush Sharma, as a turning point in her career. The 2021 movie, directed by Mahesh Manjrekar, marked her Hindi film debut.

"I'll always be grateful for the opportunity that Salman sir and Mahesh Manjrekar sir gave me because I always

wanted to see myself on the big screen. And that project changed everything for me; it made me believe in myself. When people like them see potential in you, it kind of makes you believe in yourself. 'Antim' opened so many doors for me... 'Showtime' and 'Tumse Na Hoo Payega' happened and every part, every opportunity has given me something or the other in terms of critical acclaim or people that I've worked with," she said.

In 'Musafir Café', Makwana plays Preeti, whose life becomes intertwined with Chander, a man caught between his past and present relationships. Based on Divya Prakash Dubey's best-selling novel, the series also stars Vedika Pinto. PTI

I am still crying: Vin Diesel

The actor hailed 'Fast Forever' as the 'best script I've read in decades'

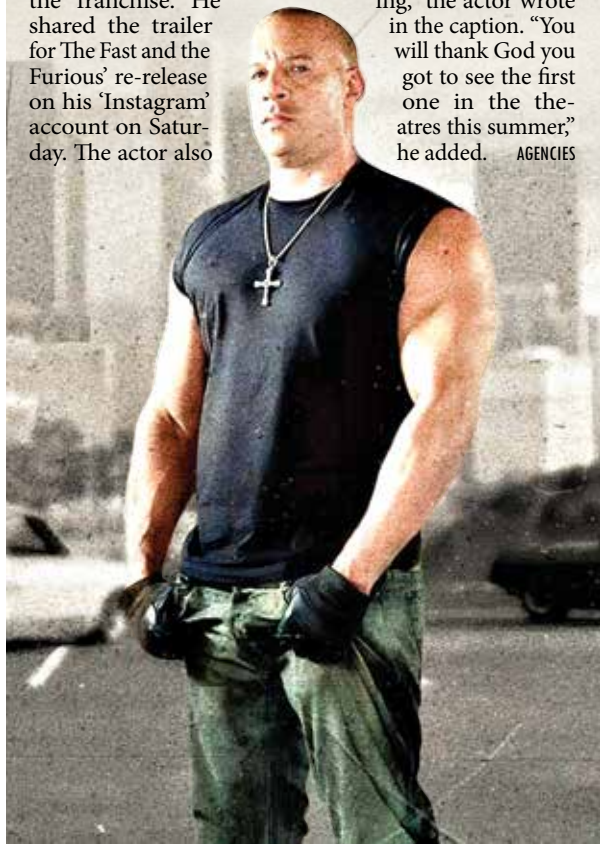
It's been 25 years since Vin Diesel first appeared as notorious street racer Dominic Toretto in the first instalment of his blockbuster action thriller franchise 'Fast & Furious'. Helmed by Rob Cohen, 'The Fast and the Furious' was released in cinemas back in June 2001. To celebrate the popular franchise's silver jubilee, the first film will be re-released in cinemas this month on August 21.

However, Diesel hinted that the re-release serves another purpose ahead of the release of 'Fast Forever', the 11th instalment of the franchise. He shared the trailer for 'The Fast and the Furious' re-release on his 'Instagram' account on Saturday. The actor also

He also teased that the upcoming 11th instalment has a hark back to the first part

teased that the upcoming 11th instalment has a hark back to the first part, which would make it even more fruitful for fans of the franchise to catch up with the first part again before they get to the next one.

"I just read the 'Fast Forever' script. It is the best script I have read in decades. I am still crying," the actor wrote in the caption. "You will thank God you got to see the first one in the theatres this summer," he added. AGENCIES



I've stopped doing cameos: Vijay Sethupathi

Vijay Sethupathi confirmed that he is now following a strict no-cameo policy and intends to stick to it, with one exception: Rajinikanth's 'Jailer 2'. And even that, he said, came with a logic that had nothing to do with the film itself.

"I've stopped doing cameos," Sethupathi said in an interview with Gobinath, adding, "I did only one recently in Jailer 2. That was so that I could see Rajini sir."

The reasoning behind the rule, he explained, is commercial rather than creative. Sethupathi said that when he appears in a cameo in another actor's film, it ends up affecting the business of his own releases. "If I do a cameo in his film, people won't even notice me. But if I do it in other films, it affects them," Sethupathi said.

He also said the decision to appear in 'Jailer 2' was driven by his personal admiration for Rajinikanth and the opportunity to learn from



He confirmed that he is now following a strict no-cameo policy and intends to stick to it, with one exception: Rajinikanth's 'Jailer 2'

someone who has sustained stardom for nearly five decades. He explained, "I did a cameo in 'Jailer 2' because I love Rajinikanth. With him, I got to learn a lot. The superstars survived in this industry for so many decades. There is so much to learn."

Despite the blanket rule, Vijay Sethupathi left a small window open. "Ultimately, the script decides it. If I feel it's the right fit, I'll do

it," he said, suggesting that the no-cameo policy is not absolute but calibrated by instinct.

Sethupathi has also spoken about his approach to villain roles, a category closely related to the cameo question. He said most antagonist parts offered to him are written as conventional villains designed to elevate the hero rather than serve the story. AGENCIES

Actor Vincent Pastore passes away at 80

Vincent Pastore, a veteran actor who played mobsters and tough guys and was best known for portraying Salvatore Bonpensiero on 'The Sopranos' died at 80.

Bob McGowan, who managed Pastore since his run on 'The Sopranos', told 'The Associated Press' that he learned of his death on Saturday from another client and actor on the show, Vincent Curatola. He said Pastore was found in his home on New York's City Island after not being heard from for a few days.

McGowan said he had been trying to reach Pastore about a possible job. "He was the most loyal client and he always gave to charity. He was the kind of guy who would help



He was best known for portraying Salvatore Bonpensiero on 'The Sopranos'

anybody, which is rare in my business," McGowan said.

Robert Attermann represented Pastore for more than 30 years,

before his time on 'The Sopranos'. While Pastore will be remembered as 'Big Pussy', he was so much

more, Attermann said in an email to the AP. "Vinny was one of the kindest, most generous people I have ever known. He treated everyone with warmth and respect, never turning down a fan who wanted a photograph or an autograph. He genuinely appreciated the people who supported him and always made them feel valued," Attermann said.

Pastore appeared in movies dating back to the 1980s, including roles in big films such as 'Goodfellas' and 'Awakenings', both in 1990. He often played gangsters. And it was one of those roles he is best known for: his 30-episode run as Bonpensiero, the friend of Tony Soprano, who becomes an FBI informant. AGENCIES

Vijay Varma recalls casting couch experience

'I got discouraged immediately,' admits the 'Dahaad' actor

Vijay Varma has built one of the most versatile careers in recent years. From 'Gully Boy' and 'Darlings' to 'Dahaad', each project has showcased a different facet of his craft, with the actor consistently delivering performances that are both distinct and memorable. Whether in a leading role or a brief appearance, Vijay has always left a lasting impression, cementing his place among the finest actors of his generation.

Recently, the actor opened up about the struggles he faced before finding success, recalling how his early attempts at modelling left him deeply discouraged after an uncomfortable encounter with a model coordinator. Speaking to Prakhar Gupta on his 'YouTube' channel, Vijay said, "I tried modelling in Hyderabad, just small-time, amateur-level work. But I came across this weird model coordinator. He started to misbehave with me a little bit, like just trying to get a little touchy-feely. I said, 'Bro, what is this? What are you doing?' So, I got

Vijay Varma has built one of the most versatile careers in recent years

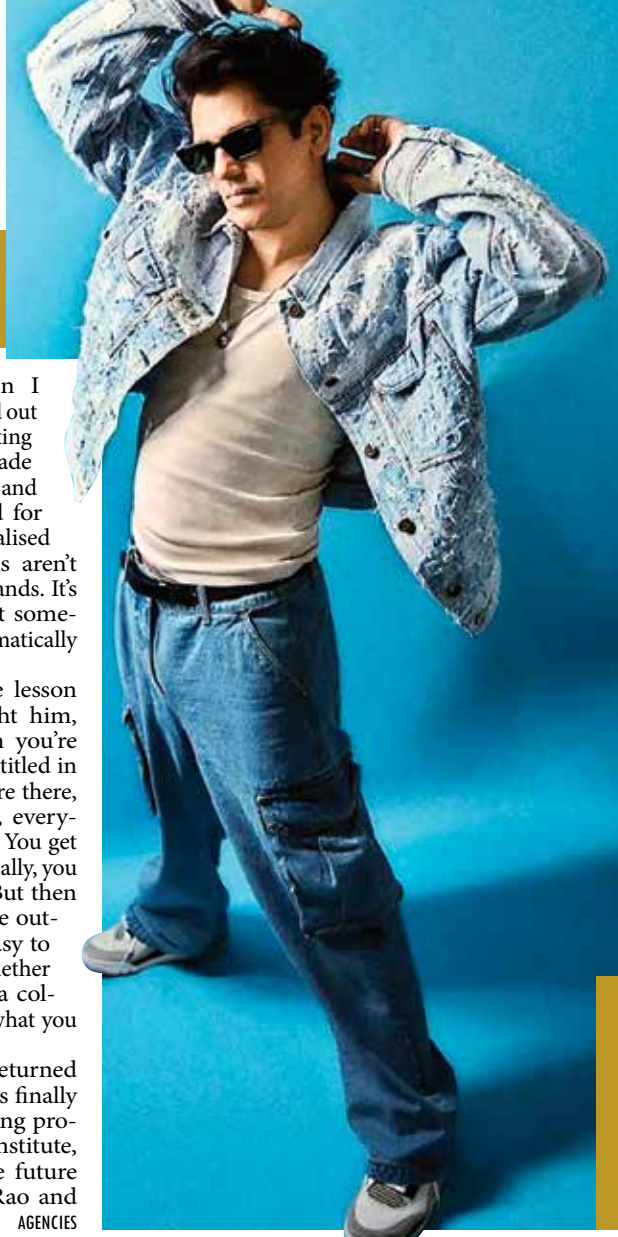
discouraged immediately. You get discouraged very quickly when you're still inexperienced. Then I thought, 'I think I should address it head-on. If acting is what I want to do, then I have to do it.'

The road to acting, however, proved no easier. "So, I went to a theatre school in Hyderabad called Sutradhar School of Acting. I told them, 'I want to learn acting'. But they turned me away. They said, 'It requires commitment, it requires dedication. This isn't something you'll do for two days and then leave.' I thought, 'They're not even giving me a chance.'"

He added, "Then I applied to FTII. I found out they had a two-year acting course. I applied, made it to the final round and got rejected. And for the first time, I realised that your dreams aren't entirely in your hands. It's not like you want something and you automatically get it. You don't."

Reflecting on the lesson those setbacks taught him, Vijay added, "When you're growing up, you're entitled in a way. Your parents are there, your family is there, everything is taken care of. You get what you want. Eventually, you get what you want. But then you realise that in the outside world, it's not easy to get what you want, whether it's getting a seat in a college or getting to do what you feel like doing."

Vijay eventually returned to FTII, where he was finally accepted into its acting programme. At the institute, he studied alongside future actors Rajkumar Rao and Jaideep Ahlawat. AGENCIES



#ViralFeed

Dia Mirza

made heads turn in her gorgeous saree at the promotion for Netflix's 'Operation Safed Sagar'

